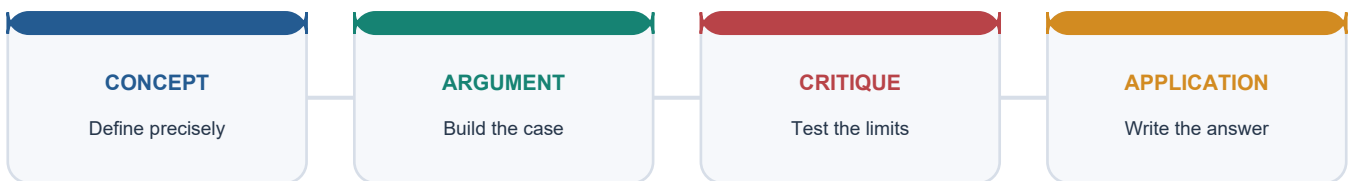


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 02 - Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 32 diagnostics with 128 option explanations, 12 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 02 - Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Proofs for the Existence of God learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique (Indian and Western)*. - UPSC Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion, item 2. □ The attributes and God-world relation presupposed by an argument belong to Notions of God, the full challenge from suffering to Problem of Evil, the phenomenology of experience to Religious Experience, and revelation and properly basic belief to Reason, Revelation and Faith; they appear here only where a premise of this clause requires them.

Evidence discipline: FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II, and Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so no objective question here is a previous-year question.

Terminology rule: the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *inference to the Lord (Īśvara-anumāna)*, *effect (kārya)*, *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)*, *unseen moral potency (adṛṣṭa)*, *karma-superintendent (karmādhyakṣa)*, *fruit-giver (karmaphaladātā)*, *authorless scripture (apauruṣeya)*, *unseen ritual potency (apūrva)*, *causal efficacy (arthakriyā-kāritva)*, *successive-or-simultaneous dilemma (krama-akrama-virodha)*, *conditioned co-arising (pratītyasamutpāda)*, *undeclared questions (avyākata)*, *ford-maker (tīrthāṅkara)*, *liberated soul (siddha)*, *omniscient embodied victor (ārihanta/kevalin)*, *four infinitudes (ananta-catustāya)*, *passion-free (vītarāga)*, *own-nature (svabhāva)*, *parsimony (lāghava)*, *self-existence (aseity)*, *essentially ordered series (per se)*, *accidentally ordered series (per accidens)*. Provenance is examinable: Anselm, *Proslogion* 2-3; Gaunilo, *In Behalf of the Fool*; Descartes, *Meditations* V; Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I q.2 a.3; Paley, *Natural Theology* (1802); Hume, *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* (1779); Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason* and *Critique of Practical Reason*; Udayana, *Nyāyakusumāñjali*, fifth section (*śābaka*); Śāntarakṣita, *Tattvasaṃgraha* with Kamalaśīla's commentary; Swinburne, *The Existence of God*; Mitchell, *The Justification of Religious Belief*, Flew, *God and Philosophy*. No page, edition or invented quotation is attached to any of them.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	12
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the confections, inversions, misattributions and ownership errors that cost marks on this clause every year: proof confused with postulate, "first cause" read temporally, Paley fused with Aquinas, Hume overstated, Jaina proofs invented, Buddhism read as denying all gods, the Nyāya Lord made a material cause, and a cumulative case read as a chain.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the demanded structure from the directive first:** three parts are ontological, two are Aquinas parts, three are Nyāya parts, one is design-with-Hume, one is the moral argument, one is Jaina, one is Buddhist and one is the a priori/a posteriori distinction.

4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 words, 15 marks about 220 to 260, 20 marks about 320 to 360.**
5. Check every answer against the three tiers: is the argument **valid**, are its premises **true**, and does its conclusion reach the **God of religion**? A script that answers only the first has left two thirds of the marks on the table.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so **no question below is a Prelims previous-year question**. All thirty-two are original UPSC-style diagnostics written against this owner's doctrine.

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique (Indian and Western)* - covering the three tiers of assessment, the a priori/a posteriori division, Anselm's two forms with Gaunilo and Kant, the modal repair, essentially ordered causal series, the Five Ways, the Leibnizian and temporal-beginning variants, Kant's charge against the cosmological argument, the composition objection, the Fifth Way against Paley's analogy, Hume's five-front critique, the exact scope of Darwin's defeat, fine-tuning and its rivals, Kant's practical postulate, the three moral routes with the Euthyphro pressure, Nyāya's efficient causation, Udayana's grounds (*hetus*), unseen moral potency (*adr̥ṣṭa*) with the karma-superintendent (*karmādhyaḥṣa*), the Jaina motive argument, the Buddhist successive-or-simultaneous dilemma (*kr̥ma-akr̥ma-virodha*), Mīmāṃsā's authorless Veda (*apauruṣeya*) with Cārvāka's attack on inference, and cumulative-case logic. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause.

MCQ 1. The three tiers on which any proof of God is assessed

A script argues that Aquinas' Second Way is formally valid, that its causal premise is defensible, and that it therefore establishes the God of classical theism. Which tier of assessment has the script omitted?

- A. Validity - whether the stated conclusion actually follows from the premises as they are set out.
- B. Soundness - whether the causal premise on which the whole inference rests is in fact true.
- C. Adequacy - whether the being reached carries the unity, necessity, personality and goodness of God.
- D. Consistency - whether the argument sits comfortably beside the other four Ways in the same article.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: validity is the tier the script has already claimed, and no critic in this debate denies that the Second Way can be set out in valid form.
- **B:** Incorrect: soundness is also claimed, since the script explicitly defends the causal premise; the objection being missed lies beyond premise-truth.
- **C:** Correct: adequacy asks whether a first efficient cause is thereby one, necessary, personal and good - the gap Kant marks when he says the passage to the most real being is unsupplied.
- **D:** Incorrect: internal consistency across the Ways is not a standard assessment tier, and a mutually consistent set of arguments could still fail all three real tests.

Examiner trap 1: Treating "valid" and "true premises" as the finish line loses the marks reserved for the conclusion-gap; every graded verdict on this clause must separately answer *what God, if any, the argument delivers*.

MCQ 2. Where the a priori / a posteriori line actually falls

Consider the following statements about the classification of theistic arguments.

1. The ontological argument is the only classical proof that reasons from the concept of God alone.
2. Nyāya's inference to the Lord (*Īśvara-anumāna*) counts as a priori because its conclusion is an omniscient being.
3. Kant's moral argument starts from the fact of obligation and is therefore a posteriori in its starting point.
4. Aquinas' Fourth Way is a priori because it works with the notion of maximal perfection.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only, because classification follows the source of the premises rather than the conclusion.
- B. 1, 2 and 4 only, because any argument reaching a perfect being must reason from that concept.
- C. 2 and 3 only, because omniscience and obligation are both non-empirical starting conditions.
- D. 1 and 4 only, because both begin from notions rather than from any observed feature.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: statement 1 holds because no other classical proof reasons from the concept alone, and statement 3 holds because Kant begins from the moral law as a datum of practical experience.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 fails because Nyāya begins from the world as a composite effect and needs invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) fixed by observation.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 2 is false for the same reason, and dropping statement 1 discards the one uncontested a priori case in the whole tradition.
- **D:** Incorrect: statement 4 fails because the Fourth Way begins from *observed degrees* of goodness, truth and nobility, not from a concept of the maximum.

Examiner trap 2: Candidates classify by the modality of the conclusion; the examiner classifies by the source of the premises, which is why an argument to a necessary being can still be thoroughly a posteriori.

MCQ 3. The two forms of Anselm's argument

Which statement states the difference between *Proslogion* 2 and *Proslogion* 3 correctly?

- A. *Proslogion* 2 was composed against Gaunilo's parody, whereas *Proslogion* 3 was composed against Kant's predicate objection.
- B. The two forms establish an identical conclusion, the second being a devotional restatement without new argumentative content.
- C. *Proslogion* 2 establishes necessary existence by aseity, while *Proslogion* 3 retreats to existence in the understanding alone.
- D. *Proslogion* 2 argues that real existence is greater than mental existence, and *Proslogion* 3 that necessary existence is greater still.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Gaunilo's *In Behalf of the Fool* replies *after* the *Proslogion*, and Kant writes seven centuries later, so neither can be the addressee of a chapter.
- **B:** Incorrect: the second form changes the modal status of the conclusion from bare existence to necessary existence grounded in self-existence (*aseity*), which is new content.
- **C:** Incorrect: this inverts the two chapters; nothing in *Proslogion* 3 weakens the conclusion, and the weaker mental-existence claim is the assumption being refuted.
- **D:** Correct: the first form uses the comparative "greater in reality", and the second upgrades it to a being whose non-existence cannot be thought - the form Anselm needs against Gaunilo.

Examiner trap 3: Reproducing only *Proslogion* 2 makes Anselm's reply to the island parody unintelligible, because that reply depends entirely on necessary existence being unavailable to any contingent thing.

MCQ 4. Gaunilo's island and what Anselm's reply actually secures

Which statement best describes the exchange between Gaunilo and Anselm?

- A. Gaunilo shows that existence is not a determining predicate, and Anselm concedes the point while retaining the devotional value of the formula.
- B. Gaunilo parodies the form with a most perfect island, and Anselm replies that necessary existence belongs to God alone and to no contingent thing.
- C. Gaunilo denies that the fool possesses the concept of God at all, and Anselm answers by appealing to the authority of scripture rather than to argument.
- D. Gaunilo accepts Anselm's first form and rejects the second, while Anselm defends the first form and abandons the second as superfluous.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the predicate objection is Kant's diagnosis, not Gaunilo's parody, and Anselm concedes nothing - he restricts the argument's scope instead.
- **B:** Correct: an island is by definition a contingent piece of the physical world and can be thought not to exist, so the principle does not reach it; the cost is that coherence of maximal greatness must now be shown independently.
- **C:** Incorrect: Anselm's whole strategy is that the fool *does* possess the concept and is refuted out of his own understanding, and the reply is argumentative rather than scriptural.
- **D:** Incorrect: Anselm relies on the second form precisely to answer the parody, so he can neither abandon it nor rest the reply on the first form alone.

Examiner trap 4: A stronger script also notes that Gaunilo wrote of the most perfect *of* islands rather than the most perfect *conceivable* island - correcting the parody before answering it signals genuine reading of the exchange.

MCQ 5. Kant's objection stated precisely

Kant's central objection to the ontological argument is best stated as which of the following?

- A. Existence is not a real or determining predicate; it posits an object rather than adding content to a concept.
- B. The concept of a maximally great being is internally contradictory in the way that a round square is contradictory.
- C. Empirical evidence for a supremely perfect being is unavailable, so the conclusion cannot be responsibly asserted.
- D. The argument commits a fallacy of composition by moving from parts of the concept to the whole concept.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: a hundred real coins contain no more concept than a hundred possible coins - only the holder's position differs - so nothing can be defined into existence.
- **B:** Incorrect: Kant does not claim demonstrable incoherence; that is the later burden the modal defender must discharge about the possibility premise.
- **C:** Incorrect: demanding empirical evidence would misdescribe an a priori argument, and Kant's point is logical rather than evidential.
- **D:** Incorrect: the composition fallacy is raised against cosmological reasoning about the contingent totality, not against Anselm's conceptual comparative.

Examiner trap 5: Writing "Kant refuted Anselm because we cannot see God" replaces a logical objection with an empiricist slogan and forfeits the predicate analysis the question is actually buying.

MCQ 6. What the modal reconstruction changes and what it does not

Malcolm, Hartshorne and Plantinga rebuild the argument around necessary existence. What is the accurate verdict on that repair?

- A. It removes Kant's objection entirely, because modal logic shows that necessary existence is a determining predicate after all.
- B. It abandons Anselm's second form and returns to the comparative reasoning of the first form dressed in symbolic notation.
- C. It survives the predicate objection but transfers the whole burden to the possibility premise, which a contrary possibility offsets.
- D. It converts the argument into an a posteriori inference, since possible worlds are established by empirical cosmological survey.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: overstating the repair is a common script fault; necessary existence is defended as a modal status rather than as a rehabilitated ordinary predicate.
- **B:** Incorrect: the modal versions work exclusively with the second form, because only necessary existence gives the inference from one possible world to every world.
- **C:** Correct: if maximal greatness is possible it is actual, but "possibly no maximally great being exists" yields the contrary result by the same logic, so coherence must be argued separately.
- **D:** Incorrect: possible-worlds semantics is a modal framework, not an empirical survey, so the argument stays a priori throughout.

Examiner trap 6: Announcing that the modal version "answers Kant" without naming the possibility premise reads as borrowed confidence; the mark lies in showing that the burden migrated rather than vanished.

MCQ 7. Essentially ordered and accidentally ordered causal series

Why does the distinction between essentially and accidentally ordered causal series matter for Aquinas' Ways?

- A. It shows that the universe must have begun a finite time ago, which is the conclusion the First and Second Ways are designed to reach.
- B. It shows that the "first" member is first in explanatory dependence, so an infinite series of derivative causes still lacks non-derivative causal power.
- C. It shows that Aquinas is arguing about temporal succession, so any beginningless universe would defeat the first three Ways outright.
- D. It shows that efficient causes and final causes are interchangeable, so the Second and Fifth Ways collapse into a single argument.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Aquinas explicitly does not need a first moment; a temporally beginningless world is compatible with a here-and-now dependence hierarchy.
- **B:** Correct: a hand moves a stick which moves a stone only while the hand acts, so borrowed power at every level never adds up to underived power, however long the chain.
- **C:** Incorrect: reading "first" temporally is the standard misreading; it makes the regress objection look decisive when it is not even on target.
- **D:** Incorrect: the Second Way concerns ordered efficient causation and the Fifth Way concerns regular directedness of non-conscious things, and they are separately assessed.

Examiner trap 7: Scripts that write "there cannot be an infinite regress" without saying *which kind* of series is at issue give the critic a free win, because accidental series may indeed be beginningless.

MCQ 8. Mapping the Five Ways to their starting points

Which pairing of an Aquinas Way with its starting point is correct?

- A. The Third Way begins from observed grades of perfection and terminates in a maximum that causes all lesser instances.
- B. The Fourth Way begins from the regular goal-directed behaviour of things that lack knowledge of their end.
- C. The Fifth Way begins from the contingency of things that are able to be and not to be within the world.
- D. The First Way begins from change understood as the reduction of potentiality to actuality by something already actual.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: grades of perfection are the Fourth Way's starting point; the Third Way begins from things that come to be and pass away.
- **B:** Incorrect: goal-directed behaviour without knowledge is the Fifth Way's datum, which is why it is a governance argument rather than an artefact analogy.
- **C:** Incorrect: contingency belongs to the Third Way; the Fifth Way never argues from possibility and necessity at all.
- **D:** Correct: motion in Aquinas means change generally, analysed as actualisation of potential, which cannot be self-supplied by what is merely potential.

Examiner trap 8: Merging the Five Ways into one "first cause" argument destroys the 2022 evaluative demand, which asks which Way is philosophically most interesting and therefore presupposes that they are genuinely distinct.

MCQ 9. Aquinas, Leibniz and the temporal-beginning argument

Which statement correctly separates the three cosmological forms?

- A. All three argue alike that the universe began to exist and that whatever begins to exist must have an external cause.
- B. Aquinas argues from present dependence, Leibniz from why a contingent totality exists, and the third form from an origin premise.
- C. Leibniz argues from a first moment of time, Aquinas from sufficient reason, and the temporal-beginning form from essentially ordered series.
- D. Aquinas and Leibniz both rely on an origin in time, whereas the temporal-beginning form is neutral about whether the universe began.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: only the temporal-beginning form makes an origin its premise; flattening the three is exactly what makes the regress objection imprecise.
- **B:** Correct: the three differ in starting point and in what each must defend - dependence hierarchy, the principle of sufficient reason, and the beginning premise respectively.
- **C:** Incorrect: this swaps the labels; sufficient reason is Leibniz's engine and the dependence hierarchy is Aquinas'.
- **D:** Incorrect: it reverses the position of every form and would make Aquinas vulnerable to cosmological findings he never needed.

Examiner trap 9: A critic who says "science shows the universe may be beginningless" defeats only the temporal-beginning form; naming which form is hit is the difference between a graded verdict and a generic one.

MCQ 10. Kant's charge against the cosmological argument

Kant argues that the cosmological argument conceals a dependence on the ontological argument. What exactly is the alleged concealed step?

- A. The claim that every event must have a cause, which Kant regards as an unjustified extension of a category beyond experience.
- B. The claim that an infinite regress of causes is impossible, which Kant treats as an illegitimate application of totality.
- C. The claim that the world is contingent, which Kant thinks smuggles in a comparison with a necessary being.
- D. The claim that a necessary being must be the most real being, which can only be shown by analysing the concept of God.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Kant's causal worry belongs to his general critique of the categories and is not the specific charge of ontological dependence.
- **B:** Incorrect: the regress issue is a separate antinomy problem and does not involve identifying the terminus with the supremely perfect being.
- **C:** Incorrect: contingency is conceded as the starting datum; the disputed move happens after a necessary being has been reached.
- **D:** Correct: the passage from "a necessary being exists" to "that being is God" is achieved only by unpacking the divine concept, which is the ontological procedure.

Examiner trap 10: Answering Kant with "but the world clearly needs a cause" misses the target, because his objection concerns the identification of the terminus rather than the demand for one.

MCQ 11. The composition objection and the brute-fact reply

Which statement most accurately reports the composition objection and the standard theistic reply?

- A. The objection is that a whole need not share a property of its parts; the reply is that the argument concerns dependence rather than a shared property.
- B. The objection is that the universe is a whole with no parts; the reply is that scientific cosmology has now settled the question.
- C. The objection is that causation is only a habit of mind; the reply is that habits of mind can still track real regularities.
- D. The objection is that God would also require a cause; the reply is that God is defined as uncaused by stipulation.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: "every member is contingent, so the collection is contingent" is the composition move, and the theist answers by restating the argument as one about explanatory dependence.
- **B:** Incorrect: nobody argues that the universe lacks parts, and appeals to settled cosmology are not what the classical exchange turns on.
- **C:** Incorrect: the habit-of-mind analysis is Hume's account of causal belief, a different line of attack from composition.
- **D:** Incorrect: bare stipulation would be question-begging; the serious reply argues that a necessary being's existence needs no external explanation.

Examiner trap 11: The reply is not complete until the answer records the standing counter - that allowing the contingent totality to be a brute fact rejects the principle of sufficient reason rather than refuting the argument.

MCQ 12. Aquinas' Fifth Way against Paley's watch

Which statement distinguishes the Fifth Way from Paley's design argument correctly?

- A. Both argue from artefacts to a designer, differing only in the illustration that each individual author happens to prefer.
- B. The Fifth Way argues from biological adaptation, whereas Paley argues from the regularity of inanimate physical law.
- C. The Fifth Way argues from regular directedness in things lacking knowledge; Paley argues by analogy from contrivance in artefacts.
- D. Paley argues that order is improbable on chance alone, whereas Aquinas argues that order is logically impossible without God.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: only Paley reasons by artefact analogy; treating the Fifth Way as an early watch argument invites Hume's analogy critique against a target it does not fit.
- **B:** Incorrect: this reverses the two, since Paley's leading case is the adapted organism and Aquinas' is the lawful behaviour of natural bodies.
- **C:** Correct: an arrow needs an archer because it lacks knowledge of its target, which is a governance argument rather than an inference from resemblance to machines.
- **D:** Incorrect: Aquinas claims explanatory necessity rather than logical impossibility, and probability language belongs to later formulations.

Examiner trap 12: Attributing the watch-and-watchmaker illustration to Aquinas is a factual error the examiner reads instantly; the watch belongs to Paley's *Natural Theology* of 1802.

MCQ 13. Hume's critique of the design argument

Which set correctly reports Hume's principal objections to the design argument?

- A. That design arguments are circular, that they misuse mathematical reasoning, and that they confuse necessity with contingency.
- B. That the world is too orderly to need explanation, that analogy is always invalid, and that intelligence is impossible without a body.
- C. That order is an illusion, that natural theology is irreligious, and that only special revelation can ground belief in God.
- D. That the world-machine analogy is weak, that a cause need only be proportioned to its effect, and that evil and plural designers fit equally well.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: circularity and mathematical misuse are not Hume's charges here, and the necessity-contingency issue belongs to his treatment of cosmological reasoning.
- **B:** Incorrect: Hume never claims that analogy is invalid as such; his complaint is that this particular analogy is remote and therefore weak.
- **C:** Incorrect: Hume does not deny that order exists, and a retreat to revelation is the opposite of the position argued in the *Dialogues*.
- **D:** Correct: these are the objections Philo presses - weak analogy, proportioning, underdetermination between one perfect designer and several imperfect ones, and evil as counter-evidence.

Examiner trap 13: Attributing the objections to Cleanthes reverses the *Dialogues*; Philo carries the critical case and Cleanthes defends the analogy.

MCQ 14. The exact scope of the Darwinian objection

What does natural selection establish against the design argument, stated with proper limits?

- A. It disproves the existence of God by showing that the universe requires no explanation of any kind.
- B. It supplies a non-intentional explanation of biological adaptation, but does not by itself explain cosmic law or fine-tuning.
- C. It shows that Paley's watch analogy is invalid because watches, unlike organisms, are manufactured objects.
- D. It shows that apparent purpose in nature is an illusion produced by human psychological projection alone.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a biological mechanism cannot disprove a metaphysical thesis, and the design argument survives in cosmological rather than biological form.
- **B:** Correct: cumulative selection removes the need for a designer of adapted organisms, which was Paley's chosen evidence, while leaving the lawfulness that selection presupposes untouched.
- **C:** Incorrect: the manufactured-object point is Hume's disanalogy complaint, available a century before Darwin and independent of him.
- **D:** Incorrect: projection is a psychological diagnosis of belief, whereas selection is a causal explanation of the adaptation itself.

Examiner trap 14: Writing "Darwin destroyed the design argument" overreaches; the mark is earned by naming precisely which evidence base was displaced and which was not.

MCQ 15. Fine-tuning and its live rivals

Which statement about fine-tuning arguments is most defensible?

- A. Fine-tuning is a demonstrative proof, since the improbabilities involved are large enough to exclude any alternative.
- B. Fine-tuning is irrelevant to philosophy of religion, because physical constants are empirical matters with no metaphysical bearing.
- C. Fine-tuning offers at best a probabilistic consideration, and must be weighed against multiverse and observer-selection rivals.
- D. Fine-tuning revives Paley's analogy exactly, since the universe is shown to be literally a machine with adjusted parts.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no probability claim yields demonstration, and the assignment of prior probabilities to constants is itself contested.
- **B:** Incorrect: the argument is philosophically live precisely because it concerns what best explains lawful conditions, not merely what the constants are.
- **C:** Correct: fine-tuning is an inference to the best explanation that must survive comparison with a multiverse ensemble and with anthropic observer-selection reasoning.
- **D:** Incorrect: contemporary formulations abandon the artefact analogy and argue probabilistically about initial conditions and constants.

Examiner trap 15: Using contemporary cosmology as if it were evidence *for* God converts a contested objection-space into a claimed proof, which the owner's evidence discipline explicitly forbids.

MCQ 16. What Kant's moral argument claims

Which statement reports Kant's moral argument accurately?

- A. God and immortality are postulates of practical reason required for the possibility of the highest good, not objects of theoretical proof.
- B. Moral obligation is unintelligible unless commanded by a divine lawgiver, so conscience theoretically demonstrates God.
- C. The existence of objective moral values proves God, since only a transcendent ground can make values stance-independent.
- D. Morality proves God because virtue is in fact rewarded with happiness in the observable course of human life.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the moral law already obligates autonomously; God enters only as a condition under which virtue and proportionate happiness could be united.
- **B:** Incorrect: the divine-lawgiver route is a different moral argument, and Kant's autonomy thesis is designed to exclude heteronomous command.
- **C:** Incorrect: the value-grounding route is an abductive argument associated with moral realism, again not Kant's postulate.
- **D:** Incorrect: the manifest absence of such proportionality in experience is exactly why Kant must postulate rather than observe.

Examiner trap 16: Writing that "Kant proves God through morality" contradicts the whole architecture of the first *Critique*; the correct formula is demolition of the theoretical proofs followed by practical reinstatement.

MCQ 17. Three moral routes and the Euthyphro pressure

Which statement correctly relates the moral-argument routes to the Euthyphro dilemma?

- A. The dilemma refutes Kant's postulate, since a postulated God cannot ground any obligation whatever.
- B. The dilemma applies only to the conscience route, because conscience is a psychological faculty rather than a metaphysical ground.
- C. The dilemma is irrelevant to all three routes, since it concerns Greek piety rather than modern moral philosophy.
- D. The dilemma bears hardest on the divine-grounding route, asking whether acts are good because willed or willed because good.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Kant's postulate does not ground obligation at all - the moral law grounds itself - so the dilemma cannot bite there in the first place.
- **B:** Incorrect: the conscience route infers a lawgiver from the phenomenology of duty and is pressed instead by naturalistic explanations of conscience.
- **C:** Incorrect: the dilemma is a general structural test of any attempt to found value on will, and its Greek origin does not limit its reach.
- **D:** Correct: if goodness depends on will, morality becomes arbitrary; if will tracks antecedent goodness, the ground is not the divine will after all.

Examiner trap 17: Merging the three routes into "the moral argument" loses the marks, because the objection that defeats one route often leaves the other two untouched.

MCQ 18. God's causal role in Nyāya

Which statement states Nyāya's position on divine causation correctly?

- A. The Lord (*Īśvara*) is the efficient and ordering cause who arranges eternal atoms, and never their material cause.
- B. The Lord is the material cause of the world, since the atoms are produced out of divine substance at each creation.
- C. The Lord is both efficient and material cause, on the model of Advaita's single reality appearing as the world.
- D. The Lord is neither efficient nor material cause but only the witness of a process governed wholly by unseen potency.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: atoms (*paramāṇu*), selves, space, time and ether are eternal and uncreated, so the Lord arranges rather than manufactures from nothing.
- **B:** Incorrect: material causation would abolish the atomism on which the whole Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika cosmology rests.
- **C:** Incorrect: the single-reality model belongs to Advaita, which in any case treats the Lord as valid only at the empirical level.
- **D:** Incorrect: a mere witness could not perform the initial conjunction of atoms or allot karmic fruits, which are the Lord's defining functions here.

Examiner trap 18: Calling Nyāya's God a creator from nothing imports an Abrahamic frame; the examinable formula is *efficient and ordering cause of an eternal material stock*.

MCQ 19. Udayana's grounds for inferring the Lord

Which statement about Udayana's enumeration of grounds (*hetus*) is most accurate?

- A. The grounds are exactly eight, fixed in wording, and every commentator glosses them identically.
- B. The grounds are drawn from perception of the Lord rather than from inference, which is why Cārvāka cannot attack them.
- C. A mnemonic verse in the *Nyāyakusumāñjali* is conventionally unpacked as eight grounds, but glosses of the last four differ.
- D. The grounds were introduced by Vātsyāyana and rejected by Udayana as insufficiently rigorous for a formal proof.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: presenting a fixed canonical eight overstates the tradition, since translations divide and gloss *padāt*, *pratyayataḥ*, *vākyāt* and *saṃkhyāviśeṣāt* differently.
- **B:** Incorrect: the whole apparatus is inferential (*anumāna*), which is exactly why Cārvāka's attack on inference to the supersensible is on target.
- **C:** Correct: the safe practice is to give the Sanskrit term with one clause of content and to flag that enumerations vary, rather than reciting a list of labels.
- **D:** Incorrect: earlier statements in Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara and Jayanta are systematised rather than rejected by Udayana's fifth section (*stabaka*).

Examiner trap 19: Listing eight Sanskrit words without a clause of content each converts an argument into vocabulary; the 2025 stem asks what proofs are offered, which means premises, not labels.

MCQ 20. Unseen moral potency and the karma-superintendent

Why does Nyāya argue that unseen moral potency (*adr̥ṣṭa*) requires a superintendent (*karmādhyaṅkṣa*)?

- A. Because unseen potency is a physical substance and every substance needs an owner to hold it in existence.
- B. Because unconscious merit and demerit cannot themselves select which agent receives which determinate fruit.
- C. Because the Veda states that the Lord dispenses fruits, and scriptural testimony settles the metaphysical question.
- D. Because karma would otherwise operate instantaneously, leaving no interval in which moral effort could matter.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: unseen potency is a quality of selves rather than a substance, and ownership would not explain intelligent allocation in any case.
- **B:** Correct: allocation is a discriminating act, and an unconscious residue has no capacity to match a specific result to a specific agent at a specific time.
- **C:** Incorrect: appealing to the Veda here would be circular, since Udayana separately argues that the Veda's authority itself presupposes a trustworthy author.
- **D:** Incorrect: timing objections belong to the Buddhist attack on a permanent cause, not to Nyāya's positive case.

Examiner trap 20: The Jaina and Mīmāṃsā reply - that karmic maturation is law-like, as poison acts without a supervisor - must be recorded, or the answer presents one side of a live dispute as settled.

MCQ 21. The Jaina case and what Jainism affirms instead

Which statement about the Jaina position is correct?

- A. Jainism proves a creator through the argument that its six substances require an intelligent external coordinator.
- B. Jainism denies a creator and also denies every form of divinity, making it indistinguishable from plain materialism.
- C. Jainism denies a creator and relocates divinity in the perfected soul, distinguishing the ford-maker from the liberated soul (*siddha*).
- D. Jainism treats the ford-maker as a responsive deity who answers petition once the four obscuring karmas are destroyed.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the six substances are advanced as making a creator redundant, which is the parsimony (*lāghava*) move rather than a proof.
- **B:** Incorrect: Jainism is non-theistic but not irreligious; omniscient perfected beings occupy the place a creator would otherwise hold.
- **C:** Correct: every ford-maker becomes a liberated soul, but not every liberated soul was a ford-maker, and neither creates, judges or responds.
- **D:** Incorrect: the ford-maker is passion-free (*vītarāga*), so responsiveness is excluded by definition and worship is commemorative.

Examiner trap 21: The 2019 stem asks for "the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism"; the first line must correct the presupposition rather than invent Jaina theistic proofs.

MCQ 22. The Buddhist dilemma about a permanent cause

The Buddhist argument from successive-or-simultaneous production (*krama-akrama-virodha*) claims which of the following?

- A. That God cannot be perceived, and that what cannot be perceived cannot be the subject of any valid inference whatever.
- B. That a permanent unchanging cause must produce either all at once or successively, and both options are fatal to the theist.
- C. That the Buddha's silence on cosmogony demonstrates that no creator exists, since an omniscient teacher would have said so.
- D. That dependent origination is compatible with a creator, provided the creator acts only at the beginning of each cosmic cycle.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the demand for perception is the Cārvāka line; Buddhist logicians argue on the invariable concomitance rather than refusing inference outright.
- **B:** Correct: all-at-once production collapses the world into a single instant, while successive production requires the acquisition of auxiliaries and hence change in God.
- **C:** Incorrect: the undeclared questions (*avyākata*) set cosmogony aside as soteriologically idle, which diagnoses the belief rather than refuting the proposition.
- **D:** Incorrect: conditioned co-arising is offered as a complete alternative that renders a creator explanatorily idle, not as a framework hospitable to one.

Examiner trap 22: Reducing the Buddhist case to "the Buddha was silent" surrenders the examinable argument; the metaphysical dilemma from Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita is what the 2018 stem is testing.

MCQ 23. Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka against Nyāya's theism

Which pairing of school and objection is correct?

- A. Mīmāṃsā argues that the world is an effect requiring a maker, while Cārvāka argues that the maker must be perceptible.
- B. Mīmāṃsā argues that unseen potency needs a dispenser, while Cārvāka argues that the Veda needs an author.
- C. Mīmāṃsā accepts the Lord as arranger of atoms, while Cārvāka accepts inference but denies scriptural testimony.
- D. Mīmāṃsā argues that the Veda is authorless and karma self-fructifying; Cārvāka argues that inference cannot reach the supersensible.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the effect-to-maker premise is Nyāya's own, and Mīmāṃsā's entire strategy is to deny that scripture needs any author at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: the dispenser argument is Nyāya's, and the authorless Veda is precisely what Mīmāṃsā asserts against Udayana's testimony grounds.
- **C:** Incorrect: Mīmāṃsā does not accept the Lord as arranger, and Cārvāka's characteristic move is to restrict valid knowledge largely to perception.
- **D:** Correct: authorless scripture (*apauruṣeya*) with self-operating ritual potency (*apūrva*) removes Udayana's testimony grounds, and the attack on inference undercuts every inferential proof at once.

Examiner trap 23: Treating Jainism, Buddhism, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka as one "Indian atheism" collapses four different objections; each denies a different premise of Nyāya's case.

MCQ 24. Cumulative-case logic and the leaky-bucket objection

Which statement about cumulative cases for theism is correct?

- A. Several probability-raising arguments may jointly support theism, against which Flew objects that leaking buckets hold no water.
- B. A cumulative case is a chain of deductions, so it is exactly as strong as its own weakest individual component.
- C. A cumulative case succeeds only if at least one of its component arguments is demonstratively valid and sound.
- D. A cumulative case is identical with inference to the best explanation, since both compare rival total hypotheses.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: probability-raising arguments can aggregate on a confirmation model, and the standard reply to Flew is that such arguments are not zero-valued, so the rope image beats the bucket image.
- **B:** Incorrect: the chain metaphor is exactly the misreading; a rope or a circumstantial legal brief is the correct model.
- **C:** Incorrect: the programme's whole point is that no component is demonstrative, which is why aggregation is being proposed at all.
- **D:** Incorrect: best-explanation reasoning compares rival total hypotheses, while a cumulative case accumulates confirmation from independent evidence-items.

Examiner trap 24: A cumulative case must be run as a *net* balance, so an answer that ignores suffering as evidence on the other side has not completed the calculation it started.

Remedial MCQs - common-error repair

These eight drills target the conflation, inversions, misattributions and ownership errors that cost marks on this clause every year. Work them only after the twenty-four core diagnostics.

MCQ 25. Repairing the confusion of proof, inference, probability and postulate

Which classification of argumentative force is correct?

- A. Anselm claims probability, Paley claims demonstration, and Kant claims an inference to the best explanation.
- B. All theistic arguments claim demonstrative force, and the differences between them are purely stylistic.
- C. All theistic arguments claim only probability, so the word "proof" in the syllabus is simply a misprint.
- D. Anselm claims deduction, design and fine-tuning claim probability or best explanation, and Kant claims a practical postulate.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this inverts every attribution, since Anselm's *reductio* is deductive in form and Paley's is explicitly an argument from analogy.
- **B:** Incorrect: design arguments in their modern form claim confirmation rather than demonstration, and Kant refuses theoretical proof altogether.
- **C:** Incorrect: the ontological family does claim deductive force, so a blanket probability reading misdescribes the tradition.
- **D:** Correct: sorting the arguments by claimed force is the first move of a graded verdict, because each force-type is defeated in a different way.

Examiner trap 25: Using "proof" as a single undifferentiated word makes every critique look equally decisive; naming the claimed force first is what allows a proportionate verdict at the end.

MCQ 26. Repairing the temporal reading of "first cause"

A candidate writes that Aquinas proves the universe began at a first moment. What is the correct repair?

- A. Aquinas does prove a temporal beginning, but only in the Third Way, which the candidate has failed to cite.
- B. Aquinas proves a temporal beginning by philosophical argument, though he also accepts it on scriptural grounds.
- C. Aquinas holds that a temporal beginning is known by faith, and his Ways argue instead from present dependence.
- D. Aquinas denies any beginning, holding an eternal universe to be demonstrable against the theologians.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Third Way argues from contingency rather than from an origin, and none of the five is a temporal-origin argument.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim that a beginning is philosophically demonstrable is precisely what Aquinas withholds.
- **C:** Correct: the Ways are compatible with a beginningless world because "first" marks explanatory priority in a here-and-now dependence hierarchy.
- **D:** Incorrect: he denies that eternity is demonstrable too, holding the question philosophically undecided either way.

Examiner trap 26: This repair is worth marks in itself: stating that Aquinas did not need a first moment immunises the answer against the most common critical objection raised in scripts.

MCQ 27. Repairing the fusion of Paley with Aquinas

Which correction of "Aquinas' watch argument" is right?

- A. The watch belongs to Paley's *Natural Theology* of 1802; Aquinas' Fifth Way argues from regular directedness without knowledge.
- B. The watch belongs to Aquinas' Fifth Way; Paley's contribution was to add the eye and the telescope as further illustrations.
- C. The watch belongs to Hume, who introduced it in the *Dialogues* in order to expose the weakness of the analogy.
- D. The watch belongs to Kant, who used it to show that purposiveness is a regulative rather than a constitutive idea.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: keeping the two apart matters because the analogy critique lands on Paley's argument and not on the governance argument.
- **B:** Incorrect: this compounds the error; the eye and telescope comparison is also Paley's, not a supplement to Aquinas.
- **C:** Incorrect: Hume attacks the artefact analogy but did not originate it, and his *Dialogues* precede Paley's book.
- **D:** Incorrect: Kant's treatment of purposiveness in the third *Critique* is a separate doctrine and involves no watch.

Examiner trap 27: Because the 2025 stem pairs the design argument with Hume's criticism, the attribution must be exact; a misattributed illustration undermines the exposition half of a two-part answer.

MCQ 28. Repairing "Hume proved there is no designer"

What does Hume's critique actually establish?

- A. That the universe is demonstrably the product of blind matter in motion over infinite time.
- B. That the inference is weak and its conclusion underdetermined, not that no designer exists.
- C. That design arguments are meaningless because theological language fails verification.
- D. That the argument is valid but unsound because its analogy premise is empirically false.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Epicurean hypothesis is offered as a live rival that the theist cannot exclude, not as an established cosmology.
- **B:** Correct: Hume attacks inferential strength and the identification of the cause, leaving the existence question open rather than closed.
- **C:** Incorrect: verification-based dismissal is a twentieth-century move belonging to the religious-language clause.
- **D:** Incorrect: Hume's complaint is that the analogy is remote and therefore weak, which affects inductive strength rather than deductive soundness.

Examiner trap 28: Overstating Hume converts a careful sceptic into a dogmatic atheist and forfeits the balance the "along with its criticism" directive is buying.

MCQ 29. Repairing the presupposition in the Jainism stem

A stem asks candidates to state and evaluate the proofs for God's existence as propounded in Jainism. What is the correct opening move?

- A. State in the first line that Jainism propounds no proof of a creator, then supply its arguments against one and its account of divinity.
- B. Reply that the question is defective and decline to answer, since no Jaina proof of a creator exists.
- C. Supply the Nyāya proofs instead, since Jainism shares the atomism on which those proofs depend.
- D. Reconstruct the six substances as an implicit proof, treating their coordination as evidence of an intelligent orderer.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: fidelity to what the school holds is the graded demand, and the answer then earns marks through the motive, regress, instrument, moral, redundancy and own-nature arguments plus the perfected-soul doctrine.
- **B:** Incorrect: refusing to answer forfeits the paper; the stem is trap-shaped rather than unanswerable.
- **C:** Incorrect: Jainism does not share Nyāya's atomism in the relevant sense, and substituting another school's material answers a different question.
- **D:** Incorrect: manufacturing a Jaina theistic proof is the exact hallucination the trap is designed to detect.

Examiner trap 29: A script that says only "Jainism is atheistic" loses half the marks; the positive doctrine of divinity as achieved perfection is part of what the stem asks to be evaluated.

MCQ 30. Repairing "Buddhism denies all gods"

Which statement corrects the claim that Buddhism denies the existence of all divine beings?

- A. Buddhism accepts a creator but denies that the creator is omnipotent or morally perfect.
- B. Buddhism denies a creator while accepting long-lived impermanent divine beings inside the round of rebirth.
- C. Buddhism denies all divine beings, and later celestial figures in Mahāyāna are purely allegorical.
- D. Buddhism suspends judgment on every question about divine beings as an undeclared matter.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the target of the Buddhist critique is precisely the world-making function, which is denied outright rather than qualified.
- **B:** Correct: Buddhism is non-theistic rather than simply atheistic - it rejects world-making by a lord (*īśvara-kāraṇa-vāda*), not devotion or the existence of gods (*deva*).
- **C:** Incorrect: Buddha-fields and celestial bodhisattvas perform genuine religious functions within the tradition's own self-understanding.
- **D:** Incorrect: the undeclared questions concern speculative cosmogony and the fate of the liberated, not the existence of gods as such.

Examiner trap 30: The distinction between rejecting a creator and rejecting divinity is the difference between a precise comparative answer and a generic "Eastern atheism" paragraph.

MCQ 31. Repairing the material-cause error in Nyāya

A candidate writes that Nyāya's Lord creates matter from nothing. What is the correct repair?

- A. The Lord creates selves but not atoms, since selves are the only entities requiring an intelligent origin.
- B. The Lord creates atoms at the start of each cycle and reabsorbs them at dissolution, as in Sāṃkhya's account.
- C. The Lord creates nothing and merely observes, since unseen potency does all the causal work in the system.
- D. Atoms, selves, space, time and ether are eternal; the Lord is the efficient cause who conjoins atoms according to unseen potency.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: selves are eternal and uncreated in this system, so partial creation of selves misstates the ontology twice over.
- **B:** Incorrect: Sāṃkhya has no lord as world-maker in its classical form, and Nyāya's atoms are never produced.
- **C:** Incorrect: a purely observing lord could not perform the initial conjunction or allot fruits, which are the argued functions.
- **D:** Correct: this states the ontology and the causal role together, which is what a comparison with Aquinas' source of being requires.

Examiner trap 31: The 2018 comparison question turns on this point: Aquinas' God is the source of *being*, Udayana's the arranger of an *eternal* material stock and the allocator of karmic results.

MCQ 32. Repairing the chain reading of a cumulative case

Which correction of "the cumulative case is only as strong as its weakest argument" is right?

- A. The saying is correct, because a cumulative case is a deductive chain in which any failed link breaks the inference.
- B. The saying is correct, because probability cannot be transferred between arguments with different subject matter.
- C. The saying misdescribes the structure: independent probability-raising strands aggregate like a rope or circumstantial brief.
- D. The saying is irrelevant, because cumulative cases are used only in Indian philosophy and not in Western natural theology.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the components are not deductions, so there is no link to break; the chain image imports the wrong logical form.
- **B:** Incorrect: independent evidence-items with different subject matter are exactly what confirmation models are designed to combine.
- **C:** Correct: the rope and the jury's converging circumstantial evidence are the standard images, and Udayana's collection of grounds is structurally the same move.
- **D:** Incorrect: the programme is prominently Western in Swinburne and Mitchell, and its Indian analogue is the point of the comparison, not a substitute for it.

Examiner trap 32: The correct verdict still concedes the underdetermination objection - aggregation may raise probability without selecting the personal, morally perfect God of worship.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

All 12 verified owner PYQs - exact wording, year and marks

All 12 items below are direct verified owner PYQs. Exact wording, years and marks are retained. Demand decoding, full model solutions, marks rationale, timing skeletons and examiner traps are pedagogic answer support, not an official answer key.

Corpus note: FACT: The audited Paper II corpus for 2018-2025 contains **12 primary-owned question-parts** for this syllabus item, out of 112 parts overall. The corpus is continuous across all eight years. Cross-linked questions owned by *Notions of God, Reason-Revelation-Faith or Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation* are not duplicated here.

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
1	2018	Q6(c)	15	Ontological - concept and existence
2	2018	Q8(a)	20	Aquinas' Five Ways vs Nyāya
3	2018	Q8(b)	15	Buddhist arguments against a creator
4	2019	Q5(e)	10	Jaina proofs
5	2020	Q6(a)	20	Is Anselm's proof logical?
6	2021	Q7(b)	15	Moral argument
7	2022	Q6(a)	20	Five Ways; most interesting
8	2022	Q8(a)	20	A priori vs a posteriori
9	2023	Q7(a)	20	Nyāya arguments
10	2024	Q7(c)	15 (10+5)	Ontological proof with criticism
11	2025	Q6(a)	20	Design argument with Hume's criticism

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
12	2025	Q7(b)	15	Nyāya proofs

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - analyse the entailment claim and deliver a reasoned verdict; not a narrative of Anselm's life
Core issue	Whether conceptual analysis can establish instantiation
Scope boundary	Stay inside the ontological family; do not drift into Aquinas or Nyāya
Ideal thesis	The concept entails necessary existence conditionally - if God exists, God exists necessarily - but conceptual entailment cannot deliver instantiation
Non-negotiables	Both forms of Anselm; Descartes; Gaunilo; Kant; the modal repair and its possibility-premise burden

Model answer (≈240 words)

The ontological argument claims a unique entailment: that the very concept of God contains, and therefore yields, God's existence. Anselm defines God as "**that than which nothing greater can be conceived**", where "greater" means more perfect. In *Proslogion* 2 he argues by *reductio*: if this being existed only in the understanding, a greater could be conceived - namely the same being existing in reality as well - which contradicts the definition. In *Proslogion* 3 the claim is strengthened: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; God therefore exists **necessarily**, by aseity. Descartes recasts this through essence-containment: existence belongs to a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle.

The entailment fails at a precise point. **Gaunilo's** perfect-island parody shows the form proves too much; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary, non-contingent existence, which an island by definition lacks. That reply protects the second form but shifts the burden onto the coherence of maximal greatness. **Kant's** objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones; existence posits an object rather than enriching a concept. Chatterjee and Datta restate this in the Indian idiom of a hundred rupees imagined in one's pocket.

Modal reconstructions retain necessary existence but transfer the whole weight to the **possibility premise**, which a parallel possibility-of-non-existence can offset.

Verdict: the concept entails existence **hypothetically**, not **actually**. Conceptual analysis yields a conditional, never an instantiation.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the entailment claim -> both Anselmian forms -> Descartes -> Gaunilo and reply -> Kant -> modal repair -> conditional verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *aliquid quo nihil maius cogitari possit*; aseity; necessary versus contingent existence.
- **Argument:** the *reductio* must be reproduced as steps, not paraphrased as a slogan.
- **Distinction:** conceptual entailment versus instantiation; Anselm's comparative form versus Descartes' essence-containment form.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, determining predicate, necessary existence, possibility premise.
- **Criticism:** Gaunilo attacks the *form*; Kant attacks the *logic of existence*. Do not merge them.
- **Comparison:** one line noting that Indian philosophy has no a priori analogue, for *pramāṇa*-theoretic reasons.
- **Conclusion:** a conditional entailment verdict - the strongest available and the one the question invites.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : State the entailment claim precisely
4 min : Proslogion 2 and 3 as numbered steps; Descartes
3 min : Gaunilo + Anselm's reply; note the shifted burden
3 min : Kant - existence is not a real predicate; thaler illustration
2 min : Modal repair; possibility-premise burden
1 min : Verdict - hypothetical entailment, not instantiation
Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing only *Proslogion* 2 and omitting necessary existence: **loses Anselm's reply to Gaunilo entirely**.
- Attributing the island to Kant or the thaler to Gaunilo: **factual error, heavily penalised**.
- Answering "yes, God exists" or "no, God does not exist": **the question is about entailment, not theology**.
- Importing the cosmological argument: **out of scope**.
- Saying the modal version "refutes Kant": **overstatement; the burden merely migrates**.
- Concluding without distinguishing conceptual from actual entailment: **the whole point of the question missed**.

PYQ 2 - 2018, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyāya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Compare</i> - a sustained axis-by-axis comparison, not two separate essays
Core issue	Whether two independent a posteriori natural theologies reach the same God by the same route
Scope boundary	Both sets of arguments must be reconstructed; neither may be reduced to a label
Ideal thesis	Structural convergence in inferring intelligence from order; decisive divergence over material causation and the role of karma
Non-negotiables	All five Ways named; at least four Nyāya arguments named in Sanskrit; the efficient/material cause distinction

Model answer (≈345 words)

Aquinas and the Naiyāyikas both practise **a posteriori** natural theology: each begins from a general feature of the world and argues to an ultimate intelligent reality. Their convergence is real, and so is their divergence.

Aquinas' **Five Ways** (*Summa Theologiae* I, q.2, a.3) argue from change to a prime mover; from efficient causation to a first cause; from contingency to a necessary being; from degrees of perfection to a maximum; and from purposive regularity in non-cognitive nature to a divine intelligence. The regress he excludes is **essentially ordered** - the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick - so "first" means **explanatory priority**, not the earliest event in time.

Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna proceeds through several routes. **Kāryāt**: composite objects are effects, since they are made of parts (*sāvayava*) and possess intermediate magnitude (*avāntara-mahattva*); material causes cannot achieve the required order and co-ordination without an intelligent maker, who must be **omniscient**, since only such a being can directly know atoms. **Āyojanāt**: inert atoms need purposive combination. **Dhṛtyādeḥ**: the world's support and dissolution require governance. **Padāt / śruteḥ**: Vedic authority presupposes an omniscient author. Finally, the argument from **adr̥ṣṭa**: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot allot determinate joys and sorrows, so God is **karmaphaladātā**.

The **convergence**: both infer intelligence from order; both add attributes stepwise rather than by definition; both are cumulative rather than single-inference systems, Udayana multiplying routes exactly as Aquinas multiplies Ways.

The **divergence** is decisive. Aquinas' God is the cause of *being*, creating *ex nihilo*; Nyāya's Īśvara is the **efficient cause only**, ordering eternal, uncreated atoms while souls, space, time and *adr̥ṣṭa* remain co-present with Him.

Aquinas' proofs are *praeambula fidei* drawn from reason alone; two Nyāya arguments are explicitly scriptural. Aquinas' God is unconditioned; Nyāya's is morally constrained by *adrṣṭa*.

Consequently the critiques differ in weight. Hume's analogy objection strikes Nyāya hardest, since its inference is expressly artefact-modelled on pot and potter; while the redundancy objection - that karma and atoms could operate without a supervisor - is uniquely Indian and, as C. D. Sharma presses it, uniquely damaging.

Verdict: the same inferential architecture, but not the same God: Aquinas' terminus is metaphysically ultimate, Nyāya's is cosmically administrative.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** a comparative frame first, then axis-by-axis treatment - never two disconnected halves.
- **Doctrine:** all five Ways correctly identified; at least four Nyāya routes with Sanskrit terms.
- **Argument:** the essentially ordered series and the *sāvayava* / *avāntara-mahattva* criteria of effect-hood must both appear.
- **Distinction:** *nimitta-kāraṇa* versus *upādāna-kāraṇa*; explanatory versus temporal priority.
- **Technical terms:** *kāryāt*, *āyojanāt*, *dhṛtyādeḥ*, *padāt*, *śruteḥ*, *adrṣṭa*, *karmaphaladātā*, *praeambula fidei*.
- **Comparison:** the Janet-Lotze-Martineau parallel, plus the observation that Western theists make God the source of existence and Nyāya only of order.
- **Criticism:** Hume's analogy objection on Nyāya; the redundancy objection; Kant's ontological-borrowing charge on Aquinas.
- **Conclusion:** same architecture, different terminus - stated as a criterion-named judgement.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Comparative frame - two a posteriori natural theologies
 4 min : Five Ways, with the per se series and "first = explanatory"
 5 min : Nyaya routes with Sanskrit terms and the omniscience step
 3 min : Convergence - inference from order; cumulative structure
 4 min : Divergence - material causation, scripture, moral constraint
 2 min : Differential critique - Hume on Nyaya; redundancy; Kant on Aquinas
 1 min : Criterion-named verdict
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing Aquinas for ten minutes and Nyāya for ten with no comparison: **the directive is unanswered; heavy loss.**
- Calling Nyāya's God the material cause: **the topic's most penalised factual error.**
- Reducing the Five Ways to "first cause": **collapses four distinct arguments.**
- Omitting Sanskrit terminology: **loses the Optional's technical premium.**
- Claiming Nyāya is "the Indian Aquinas" without qualification: **false equivalence.**
- Ending with "both are similar": **an ungraded conclusion earns no evaluative marks.**

PYQ 3 - 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Critically evaluate the Buddhist arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically evaluate</i> - state the arguments, then judge their force, including where they fail
Core issue	Whether conditioned arising renders a creator explanatorily and morally unnecessary
Scope boundary	The target is <i>jagat-kartā</i> , a world-maker; Buddhism's rejection of the sacred is not at issue
Ideal thesis	The arguments are decisive against an anthropomorphic purposive world-maker, weaker against a metaphysically refined classical theism
Non-negotiables	At least four canonical lines, plus the theistic replies

Model answer (≈245 words)

Buddhism rejects a creator God (*jagat-kartā*) without rejecting spiritual ultimacy; its critique is a systematic refusal of **explanatory surplus** rather than bare atheism.

Four canonical lines recur. First, if God is **eternal and unchanging**, genuine creation is hard to explain, since willing or producing appears to involve change; Dharmakīrti-type reasoning sharpens this - a permanent, immutable cause fully present at all times should produce its effect always and at once, never in temporal succession. Second, if God creates **from desire or purpose**, this implies lack, preference or incompleteness, which is inconsistent with perfection. Third, **suffering and evil** sit uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. Fourth, **dependent origination** already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, so a creator is redundant. To these may be added the methodological point that questions of a first beginning fall among the *avyākṛta*, undeclared because soteriologically idle - the wounded man who insists on knowing the archer before the arrow is removed.

Evaluation must be even-handed. The change objection assumes a **temporal model of divine willing**; classical theism answers with a single eternal act producing a temporal effect. The desire objection assumes creation must remedy a lack; theists appeal to gratuitous diffusive goodness. Most importantly, Nyāya replies that dependent origination explains **sequence** but not **desert-appropriate allocation**: an unconscious nexus cannot proportion determinate fruit to determinate merit. Explanatory economy, moreover, is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

Verdict: Buddhism establishes that a coherent, ethically serious cosmology is possible without a creator. That is a substantial philosophical achievement - but it shifts the burden of proof rather than closing the question.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** clarify the target -> four to six arguments as reconstructions -> theistic replies -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *pratītyasamutpāda*; the *avyākṛta* questions; anti-*Īśvara* argumentation in Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita.
- **Argument:** the immutability-succession incompatibility must be stated as an argument, not as an assertion.
- **Distinction:** rejecting a creator ≠ atheism in the Western sense; *nāstika* = denier of Vedic authority.
- **Technical terms:** *jagat-kartā*, *pratītyasamutpāda*, *avyākṛta*, explanatory parsimony.
- **Comparison:** one line linking Buddhist economy to Hume's Epicurean hypothesis and Darwinian sufficiency.
- **Criticism:** the Nyāya allocation reply is the strongest counter and must appear.
- **Conclusion:** decisive against a purposive anthropomorphic maker; inconclusive against refined theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Clarify the target - jagat-karta, not the sacred
6 min : Immutability/succession · desire implies lack · evil ·
 dependent origination · avyakṛta silence · freedom-karma dilemma
4 min : Replies - eternal act, diffusive goodness, Nyaya on allocation,
 economy is methodological
2 min : Note that nastika means denial of Vedic authority
1 min : Graded verdict
Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Treating the arguments as a proof of atheism: **misstates their logical status**.
- Writing a devotional account of the Buddha instead of arguments: **no philosophical content**.
- Omitting the replies in a "critically evaluate" question: **the directive is half-answered**.
- Calling Buddhism *nāstika* in the sense of "spiritually nihilistic": **terminological error**.
- Confusing the Buddhist argument from evil with the full problem of evil: **scope drift**.
- Ending with "hence God does not exist": **unwarranted and penalised**.

PYQ 4 - 2019, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

"State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>State and evaluate</i> - exposition plus judgement, in 150 words
Core issue	In what sense Jainism has a God at all, and what it proves about that God
Scope boundary	Do not write a general essay on Jaina metaphysics
Ideal thesis	Jainism denies God as creator but affirms godhead ; its proofs establish attainable perfection, not a cosmic maker
Non-negotiables	The denial/affirmation disambiguation; at least two positive proofs; one evaluative limit

Model answer (≈160 words)

Jainism denies God as **creator**: the world was never created, since all substances are eternal and change only through modes (*utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*). But "**Jainism denies God, and yet does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god.**"

Its proofs are accordingly proofs of attainable divinity. First, from the **intrinsic nature of the jīva**: every soul possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*), obscured by material karma rather than absent - for we observe degrees of knowledge, not its absence. Second, from **gradation to a limiting case**: *matī*, *śruta*, *avadhi* and *maṇḍaparyāya* mark progressive removal of karmic obstruction, whose complete removal is **kevala-jñāna**, omniscience. Third, from the **testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras** (*āpta-vacana*), mortals who won liberation by personal effort - "we are all potential Jinās".

Evaluation: these establish a plural, achieved, non-creative godhood and rest wholly on Jaina premises - intrinsic omniscience and material karma. They neither prove nor attempt a cosmic God. Sharma's dilemma bites: if karma is inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if separable, bondage is.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** disambiguate "God" -> three proofs -> one internal criticism -> verdict, all within 150 words.
- **Doctrine:** *ananta-catuṣṭaya*; the five knowledges; *kevala-jñāna*; *siddha* and Tīrthaṅkara.
- **Argument:** the gradation-to-limiting-case inference must be visible as an inference.
- **Distinction:** God as world-maker versus God as perfected being; Jaina karma is **material (pudgala)**, not *adrṣṭa*.
- **Technical terms:** *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*, *āpta-vacana*, *tri-ratna*, *nāstika* correctly glossed.
- **Comparison:** one clause contrasting this with Nyāya's efficient-cause creator.
- **Criticism:** the bondage/liberation dilemma, or the internality of the premises.
- **Conclusion:** a soteriological rather than cosmological theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Denies creator, affirms godhead - the controlling distinction
4 min : Three proofs, compressed but as arguments
2 min : Evaluation - premises internal to Jaina metaphysics; Sharma's dilemma
1 min : Verdict - soteriological, not cosmological, theism
Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "Jainism is atheistic, so there are no proofs": **misreads the question and forfeits most marks.**
- Substituting a general account of *anekāntavāda* or the *tri-ratna*: **off-question.**
- Equating Jaina karma with Nyāya's *adrṣṭa*: **doctrinal error.**
- Calling the *siddha* a creator or governor: **contradicts the doctrine.**
- Exceeding the word limit at the cost of the evaluation: **the second directive verb is lost.**

PYQ 5 - 2020, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Is the ontological proof for the existence of God by St. Anselm logical? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss</i> an evaluative question - you must take a position on logicality , not merely on truth
Core issue	Whether the argument is formally valid, and whether its validity is purchased by an illegitimate use of "exists"
Scope boundary	Anselm centrally; Descartes and modal versions only as extensions
Ideal thesis	The argument is formally coherent as a reductio , but it is not <i>logically compelling</i> , because its crucial premise misclassifies existence
Non-negotiables	Both forms; the validity/soundness distinction; Gaunilo; Kant; a stated verdict

Model answer (≈350 words)

Whether Anselm's proof is "logical" must be split into two questions: is it **valid**, and is its key premise **legitimate**?

Anselm's *Proslogion* 2 argument is a *reductio*. Suppose that than which nothing greater can be conceived exists in the understanding alone. Existing in reality is greater than existing in the understanding alone. Then a greater than the greatest conceivable could be conceived - a contradiction. Therefore it exists in reality. Formally this is impeccable: given the definition and the comparative premise, the conclusion follows. *Proslogion* 3 strengthens it: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can, so God exists **necessarily**; since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded.

The difficulty is not the inference but the **comparative premise**. **Gaunilo**, in *In Behalf of the Fool*, constructs a parallel for the most perfect conceivable island; if the form is valid, it manufactures islands. Anselm replies that only God is defined as having eternal and independent existence, whereas an island - a piece of land surrounded by water - is by definition contingent and can without contradiction be thought not to exist. The reply succeeds for the second form, but it transfers the burden: it must now be shown that **maximal greatness is a coherent notion with an intrinsic maximum**, whereas island-perfections plainly are not.

Kant supplies the decisive diagnosis. Existence is not a real predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones. If so, "existing in reality is greater" is not a legitimate comparison of concepts at all, and the argument is valid only in the trivial sense that it correctly draws out what was illicitly built in. Modern quantificational analysis reinforces this by treating existence as second-order.

Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and Plantinga preserve necessary existence and are formally valid in S5; but their **possibility premise** - that a maximally great being is possible - is precisely what is disputed, and a symmetrical possibility-of-non-existence yields the opposite conclusion.

Verdict: Anselm's proof is **logically well-formed but not logically compelling**. It is valid in form, question-begging in premise, and at best establishes a conditional: if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** split "logical" into validity and legitimacy -> both forms -> Gaunilo -> Kant -> modal -> explicit verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the *reductio* structure; aseity; necessary existence.
- **Argument:** the comparative premise must be isolated as the load-bearing step.
- **Distinction:** validity versus soundness; a well-formed argument versus a compelling one.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, determining predicate, S5, possibility premise, second-order quantification.
- **Comparison:** one line noting Chatterjee-Datta's parallel hundred-rupees formulation in the Indian tradition.
- **Criticism:** Gaunilo attacks the form's generality; Kant attacks the concept of existence. Both are needed.

- **Conclusion:** an explicit, defended answer to "is it logical?" - hedging is penalised here more than anywhere else in this topic.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Split the question - valid? legitimate premise?
 5 min : Proslogion 2 as a reductio; Proslogion 3 and necessary existence
 4 min : Gaunilo, Anselm's reply, and the transferred burden
 5 min : Kant's diagnosis; the quantificational reinforcement
 3 min : Modal versions and the possibility premise
 2 min : Explicit verdict - well-formed, not compelling
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Answering "no, because God cannot be proved": **does not engage logic at all.**
- Treating validity and soundness as one thing: **the question's whole hinge is missed.**
- Omitting *Proslogion* 3: **Anselm's reply to Gaunilo becomes unintelligible.**
- Presenting Kant's objection as "Kant said God does not exist": **serious misattribution.**
- Refusing to give a verdict: **"Discuss" with an evaluative stem requires a position.**

PYQ 6 - 2021, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Give a critical account of moral argument to prove the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critical account</i> - full exposition plus sustained criticism
Core issue	Whether moral experience can establish, or rationally require, belief in God
Scope boundary	Both forms of the moral argument; the other proofs only as contrast
Ideal thesis	The inferential form begs the question; Kant's postulational form is defensible but is not a proof
Non-negotiables	Kant's three postulates; the highest good; "ought implies can"; Euthyphro correctly aimed

Model answer (≈250 words)

The moral argument claims that ethical experience presupposes the reality of God. It takes two very different forms.

The **first form** is a straightforward inference: from objective moral laws to a divine Law Giver, or from conscience to a God whose voice it is. Newman's *Grammar of Assent* argues that feeling shame and fear before conscience implies One before whom we are ashamed. The objection is fatal: this assumes that moral values admit of **no naturalistic explanation** in terms of human needs, social structure or practical reason. That assumption is precisely what is in dispute, so the argument **begs the question**.

The **second form**, Kant's, is not strictly a proof. Having demolished the speculative proofs in the *Critique of Pure Reason* - the ontological by denying that existence is a real predicate, the cosmological by showing it borrows the ontological - Kant reinstates God in the *Critique of Practical Reason*. The moral law obligates us to promote the **highest good**, virtue together with proportionate happiness. "Ought implies can" requires that the highest good be really possible. But holiness is unattainable in finite time, and nature does not proportion happiness to desert. Hence three **postulates of practical reason**: freedom, immortality and God - objects of rational faith, practically necessary and theoretically undemonstrable.

Criticism cuts several ways. The postulate may be a projection of a desire for cosmic fairness, though Kant answers that it arises from the structure of moral reason, not from reward-seeking, which would be heteronomy. If morality is autonomous, God's role is confined to realisability, not obligation - which also insulates Kant from the **Euthyphro dilemma**, whose real target is divine-command theory. Adequacy remains the deepest problem: as Hick notes, moral values cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, self-existent personal creator.

Verdict: as a proof it fails, and Kant never offered it as one; as an account of what moral seriousness rationally presupposes, it retains genuine force. Nyāya's *karmaphaladātā* addresses the same problem but claims knowledge where Kant claims only hope.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** two forms distinguished -> Kant's derivation as steps -> four to five criticisms -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *summum bonum*; the three postulates; *Vernunftglaube*; autonomy.
- **Argument:** "ought implies can" must be shown doing work, not merely quoted.
- **Distinction:** postulate versus demonstration versus empirical hypothesis.
- **Technical terms:** heteronomy, practical reason, fact of reason, Euthyphro.
- **Comparison:** the Nyāya *karmaphaladātā* parallel, with the epistemic contrast.
- **Criticism:** projection, autonomy tension, adequacy; and Euthyphro aimed at divine-command theory, not Kant.
- **Conclusion:** it establishes a rational hope, not a demonstrated being.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Two forms flagged at once
 2 min : Newman's inferential form and the question-begging objection
 5 min : Kant - CPR demolition, then the highest good and three postulates
 4 min : Criticism - projection, autonomy, Euthyphro's real target, adequacy
 2 min : Nyaya comparison
 1 min : Graded verdict
 Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "Kant proves God through morality": **the single most penalised error in this topic.**
- Listing only one postulate: **loses the systematic structure.**
- Aiming Euthyphro at Kant: **misapplied objection.**
- Treating the postulate as a reward-motive: **contradicts Kant's own doctrine of autonomy.**
- Omitting the first form entirely: **"critical account" of the moral argument requires both.**
- Omitting any Indian comparison in a Paper II answer: **loses the comparative premium.**

PYQ 7 - 2022, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Present a critical exposition of different arguments offered by St. Thomas Aquinas to prove the existence of God also known as 'Five Ways'. Which one of them do you find philosophically most interesting? Give reasons in support of your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two directives: <i>critical exposition</i> of all five, and a defended personal judgement
Core issue	Whether the Ways are distinct arguments, and which best withstands scrutiny
Scope boundary	All five must appear; the chosen Way must then be developed further
Ideal thesis	The Ways are five distinct arguments; Way 3 (or Way 5) is most interesting, for stated philosophical reasons
Non-negotiables	The <i>per se</i> / <i>per accidens</i> distinction; "first" as explanatory; a reasoned choice with objections handled

Model answer (≈350 words)

Aquinas' Five Ways (ST I, q.2, a.3) are **five distinct a posteriori arguments**, not one argument restated. Each begins from a general feature of the world and concludes with the cautious formula "and this everyone understands to be God" - itself an admission that further work is needed to identify the terminus with the God of religion.

Way 1 argues from motion, understood as the reduction of potentiality to actuality: whatever is moved is moved by another, and an essentially ordered series of movers cannot regress infinitely, so there is an unmoved mover. **Way 2** argues from an order of efficient causes to a first efficient cause. **Way 3** argues from contingency: if everything were merely possible, at some time nothing would have existed, and nothing would exist now; hence there is a necessary being, and ultimately one necessary of itself. **Way 4** argues from degrees of goodness and truth to a maximum which causes all perfection. **Way 5** argues from the regular goal-directed activity of things lacking cognition to a directing intelligence, as the arrow is directed by the archer.

Critically, the excluded regress is **essentially ordered** - the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick - so "first" denotes **explanatory priority**, not chronological firstness. Aquinas himself concedes the difficulty of excluding an endless series of *events*, and holds that the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration; neo-Thomists accordingly recast the excluded series as simultaneous dependence. Way 3 is vulnerable to a quantifier shift at the step from "each thing at some time is not" to "at some time nothing is". Way 4 requires the Platonic machinery of participation, since degrees of heat do not entail a hottest object. Way 5 is exposed to Hume's analogy objection and, in Paley's later form, to Darwin. Kant's overarching charge is that the passage from "a necessary being" to "the most real being" is the ontological argument in disguise.

Most interesting: Way 3. It alone poses the deepest question - why is there anything at all rather than nothing? - and it is the only Way whose central premise, the Principle of Sufficient Reason, remains a live philosophical dispute against brute-fact naturalism. Its conclusion is also modally strongest: not merely a first mover but a being whose non-existence is impossible. That it is simultaneously the most vulnerable, at the quantifier-shift step, makes it philosophically the richest rather than the weakest - a bad argument for the best question is more instructive than a safe argument for a smaller one.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** all five expounded compactly -> critical apparatus -> a defended choice with its own objection answered.
- **Doctrine:** act and potency; *per se* causal series; contingency and necessity; participation.
- **Argument:** each Way in one or two premise-steps, never as a bare label.
- **Distinction:** explanatory versus temporal priority; Way 2 (causal dependence) versus Way 3 (modal status).
- **Technical terms:** *per se* / *per accidens*, PSR, *ab alio* / *a se*, quantifier shift.
- **Comparison:** one line on Nyāya's parallel cumulative structure, or on the Kalām's contrasting temporal claim.
- **Criticism:** Hume, Kant and one internal weakness per Way where space allows.
- **Conclusion:** the personal judgement must be argued, with a criterion named - depth of question, modal strength, or contemporary liveness.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Frame - five distinct a posteriori arguments
 7 min : Ways 1-5, each as premises
 5 min : Critical apparatus - *per se* series, Aquinas on eternity, quantifier shift, participation, Hume/Darwin, Kant
 5 min : The chosen Way, defended, with one objection met
 2 min : Conclusion naming the criterion of choice
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Presenting the Ways as one "first cause" argument: **destroys the exposition mark.**
- Choosing a Way but giving no philosophical reasons: **the second directive is unanswered.**
- Choosing Way 2 and glossing it as "God started the universe": **misrepresents Aquinas.**
- Introducing Paley's watch as Aquinas': **factual error.**
- Asserting that Aquinas proves a temporal beginning: **contradicts ST I q.46 a.2.**
- Omitting all criticism in a "critical exposition": **half the directive lost.**

PYQ 8 - 2022, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the main points of distinction between a priori and a posteriori arguments for the existence of God. Which one according to you should be preferred over the other? Give reasons and justifications for your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Discuss the distinction, and defend a preference with reasons
Core issue	The trade-off between modal strength and evidential contact
Scope boundary	Use exemplars from both families, Indian and Western; do not merely define
Ideal thesis	A criterion-relative preference: a posteriori for evidential respectability, a priori for modal strength, neither for religious adequacy
Non-negotiables	A multi-axis distinction table in prose; at least three exemplars; an explicit preference

Model answer (≈345 words)

The distinction is not merely one of subject matter but of **evidential source, method, modal outcome and characteristic vulnerability**.

An **a priori** argument reasons from the concept of God alone, without empirical premises. The ontological argument is the sole classical instance: Anselm derives existence, and then necessary existence, from the concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived; Descartes derives it from the essence of a supremely perfect being. Its method is conceptual analysis, and its promised reward is enormous - if it works, it yields a **necessary** God, immune to empirical revision.

An **a posteriori** argument reasons from some general feature of the world. Aquinas' Ways begin from motion, causation, contingency, degrees and purposive order; Paley begins from means-end adjustment; Kant's moral argument begins from the structure of moral obligation; and Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna begins from the world as a composite effect requiring an omniscient intelligent maker. Their method is inference from effect to cause, or inference to the best explanation, and their conclusions are correspondingly **probable** rather than necessary.

Their vulnerabilities differ accordingly. The a priori route faces Kant's charge that existence is not a real predicate, and Gaunilo's demonstration that the form proves too much; modal repairs shift the burden to an unestablished possibility premise. The a posteriori route faces Hume: the world-artefact analogy is weak, and from a finite effect one may infer only a finite cause. It is also exposed to scientific advance - Darwin against Paley, cosmological alternatives against the Kalām - whereas the a priori route is immune to empirical developments precisely because it is empirically empty.

Preference. I prefer the **a posteriori** route, on three grounds. First, **dialectical**: it begins from premises the opponent already grants - that things change, that order exists, that we are obligated - whereas the a priori route asks the opponent to grant a contested concept. Second, **epistemic**: it does not require the illegitimate treatment of existence as a determining predicate. Third, **traditional convergence**: two independent civilisations, Thomist Europe and Nyāya India, arrived at structurally similar a posteriori arguments, which suggests the route tracks something real in the explanatory demand.

But the preference must be **graded**. The price is that a posteriori arguments deliver at most a probable, possibly finite cause, and never the God of developed religion. If the criterion were modal strength rather than evidential contact, the ranking would reverse. **Neither route alone secures religious adequacy** - which is why every tradition eventually supplements proof with experience, testimony or faith.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: multi-axis distinction -> exemplars on both sides -> differential vulnerabilities -> a preference with three named reasons -> a graded qualification.
- **Doctrine**: ontological versus cosmological/teleological/moral/Nyāya families.
- **Argument**: the trade-off between modal strength and evidential contact must be made explicit.

- **Distinction:** conceptual entailment versus inference to a cause; necessity versus probability.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, *vyāpti*, inference to the best explanation, underdetermination.
- **Comparison:** Nyāya must appear as an a posteriori exemplar - this is a Paper II answer.
- **Criticism:** Kant and Gaunilo on one side; Hume and Darwin on the other.
- **Conclusion:** criterion-relative preference, explicitly named, never a bare "both are useful".

Compact skeleton and timing

3 min : Four axes of distinction - source, method, modality, vulnerability
 5 min : A priori exemplars - Anselm, Descartes, and the modal repair
 5 min : A posteriori exemplars - Ways, Paley, Kant, Nyaya
 3 min : Differential vulnerabilities
 4 min : Preference with three reasons
 1 min : Graded qualification naming the alternative criterion
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Defining the terms and stopping: **the second directive is ignored.**
- Equating a priori with "certain" and a posteriori with "uncertain": **conceptual error.**
- Omitting Nyāya: **a Paper II answer with no Indian material is under-marked.**
- Preferring one without naming a criterion: **an unjustified preference.**
- Claiming a priori arguments are Western and a posteriori Indian: **historically false.**
- Concluding "both are equally good": **fails the explicit demand for a preference.**

PYQ 9 - 2023, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Critically examine the arguments of Nyāya for the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> - full reconstruction, then rigorous evaluation
Core issue	Whether Nyāya's inferences establish an omniscient efficient cause
Scope boundary	The arguments , though a brief statement of the nature of Īśvara is needed to make them intelligible
Ideal thesis	Individually inconclusive and jointly cumulative; the redundancy objection is the deepest threat
Non-negotiables	Four to five arguments in Sanskrit; the efficient/material cause thesis; Indian critics before Western ones

Model answer (≈350 words)

Nyāya offers a rational, inferential theism. Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient special self, the **first efficient cause** - a demiurgus or builder of the ordered universe - **not its material cause**; He is also preserver and destroyer, which distinguishes Nyāya theism from deism.

Kāryāt - the causal argument. All composite objects of the world are effects, since they are made of parts (*sāyava*) and possess intermediate magnitude (*avāntara-mahattva*); space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities, and atoms and *manas* as simple infinitesimals. Material causes alone cannot attain the order, direction and co-ordination that produce such effects. The intelligent cause must therefore have direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it - and must be **omniscient**, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms.

Āyojanāt - inert atoms cannot combine purposively of themselves. **Dhṛtyādeḥ** - the world's support, maintenance and dissolution require governance. **Padāt / āptaprāmānya** - the Veda's authority derives from an omniscient author, as a science's authority derives from its founder; the jīva cannot be that author, since supramundane realities exceed ordinary cognition. **Śruteḥ** - scripture directly testifies to God. Finally, the argument from **adṛṣṭa**: differences of lot require causes; karma supplies them; but the time-gap requires a persisting stock of merit and demerit; and adṛṣṭa,

being **unintelligent**, cannot allot precisely the joy and sorrow deserved, while individual selves neither know nor control it. Hence God is *karmaphaladātā*.

Critically: the **circularity** charge against the last two arguments is answered by distinguishing the order of existence (God creates the Veda) from the order of knowledge (the Veda discloses God); the **bodiless-agent** objection is met by a dilemma. But the deeper objections stand. Mīmāṃsā holds the Veda *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva* self-maturing, which dissolves two arguments at once. Buddhism and Jainism hold that conditions and material karma suffice. Cārvāka denies inference's reach. Śāṅkara presses a dilemma on whether atoms are active or inactive, and treats Nyāya's God as merely *saguṇa*. C. D. Sharma's redundancy objection is sharpest: this God is "reduced to the status of a supervisor", His hands and feet "chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the *Adṛṣṭa*".

Verdict: the arguments are individually inconclusive but cumulatively serious, in Udayana's manner. They share the limits of all a posteriori theism - Chatterjee and Datta themselves conclude, with Kant and Lotze, that God cannot be deduced from anterior premises and must be known through direct experience.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** nature of Īśvara in two lines -> four to five arguments as reconstructions -> internal replies -> external critiques -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** efficient not material cause; *ṣaḍ-aiśvarya*; *prayojaka kartā*; *karmaphaladātā*.
- **Argument:** the *sāvaṃyava* / *avāntara-mahattva* criteria and the derivation of omniscience must both be present.
- **Distinction:** order of existence versus order of knowledge; theism versus deism.
- **Technical terms:** *kāryāt*, *āyojanāt*, *dhṛtyādeḥ*, *padāt*, *śruteḥ*, *adrṣṭa*, *apauruṣeya*, *apūrva*, *saguṇa*.
- **Comparison:** Janet, Lotze and Martineau as parallels - with the divergence over existence versus order.
- **Criticism:** Indian critics first (Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist, Jaina, Cārvāka, Advaita), then the redundancy objection.
- **Conclusion:** cumulative but not demonstrative; note the textbook tradition's own experiential turn.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Īśvara - efficient cause, preserver, destroyer; theism not deism
7 min : Karyat (with omniscience derivation), ayojanat, dhṛtyadeh,
padat/sruteh, adrsta
4 min : Internal replies - circularity, bodiless agent
5 min : External critiques - Mimamsa, Bauddha, Jaina, Carvaka, Sankara,
Sharma's redundancy
3 min : Graded verdict + Chatterjee-Datta's experiential conclusion
Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Calling God the material cause: **the single worst error available here.**
- Listing the proofs without reconstructing any: **descriptive, not analytical.**
- Using only Hume and Kant as critics: **ignores the Indian debate the question presupposes.**
- Conceding the Veda-God circularity: **the classical reply exists and should be given.**
- Confusing *adrṣṭa* with Jaina material karma: **doctrinal error.**
- Concluding "hence Nyāya proves God": **ungraded and indefensible.**

PYQ 10 - 2024, Q7(c), 15 marks (10 + 5)

Exact question

"Present an exposition of ontological proof for the existence of God along with its criticism."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explicitly split: 10 marks exposition + 5 marks criticism
Core issue	Faithful reconstruction, then targeted objection
Scope boundary	Allocate roughly two-thirds of the space to exposition
Ideal thesis	A clear reconstruction of both Anselmian forms and Descartes, criticised through Gaunilo and Kant
Non-negotiables	The mark split must be visibly respected in the answer's proportions

Model answer (≈250 words)

Exposition (10). The ontological proof is the sole classical **a priori** argument: it moves from the concept of God to God's existence without any empirical premise. Anselm defines God as "**that than which nothing greater can be conceived**", where "greater" means more perfect - and deliberately not as "the most perfect being that there is", which would guarantee nothing. In *Proslogion* 2 he argues by *reductio*: even the fool who denies God understands the concept; but if this being existed in the understanding alone, we could conceive a greater - the same being existing in reality as well - which contradicts the definition; therefore it exists in reality. In *Proslogion* 3 he strengthens the conclusion: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; and since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. God therefore exists **necessarily**, by aseity. Descartes reformulates it in *Meditations* V: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle, or a valley to a mountain; a perfect being lacking existence would lack a perfection.

Criticism (5). **Gaunilo**, in *In Behalf of the Fool*, parodies the form with the most perfect conceivable island; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary existence, an island being by definition contingent - but the reply then requires that maximal greatness be coherent. **Kant's** objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate; a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. Modal repairs preserve validity but relocate the burden onto an unestablished **possibility premise**.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** the 10 + 5 split must be visible, ideally with the exposition twice the length of the criticism.
- **Doctrine:** both Anselmian forms plus Descartes; the fool; aseity.
- **Argument:** the *reductio* reproduced as steps.
- **Distinction:** "greatest conceivable" versus "greatest that there is" - a mark-winning nuance.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, necessary existence, possibility premise.
- **Comparison:** optional single line that Indian philosophy has no a priori analogue.
- **Criticism:** Gaunilo on form, Kant on the concept of existence - both, in that order.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives: a conditional, not an instantiation.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : A priori status and Anselm's definition, precisely worded
5 min : *Proslogion* 2, then *Proslogion* 3; then Descartes
1 min : Note the "conceivable" vs "that there is" nuance
4 min : Gaunilo + reply; Kant; modal burden
1 min : What survives - a conditional
Total : 12 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Ignoring the 10 + 5 split and writing a balanced essay: **structural penalty**.
- Giving criticism first: **inverts the stated weighting**.
- Reproducing only Descartes: **the question says "ontological proof", whose primary text is Anselm**.
- Confusing Gaunilo's and Kant's objections: **factual error**.
- Omitting *Proslogion* 3: **the reply to Gaunilo cannot then be stated**.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Present an account of Design argument to prove the existence of God along with its criticism by David Hume."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Exposition plus a named critic - Hume specifically, not general criticism
Core issue	Whether order and adaptation license an inference to an intelligent, single, infinite, good designer
Scope boundary	Hume must dominate the critical half; Darwin and fine-tuning are extensions, not substitutes
Ideal thesis	Hume defeats the argument as a demonstration and blocks the passage to the God of theism, without disproving a designer
Non-negotiables	Aquinas' Way 5 distinguished from Paley; Paley's three riders; at least four Hume fronts; the 1779/1802 chronology

Model answer (≈355 words)

The design or teleological argument runs from Plato's *Timaeus* through Aquinas to the modern period. Two forms must be distinguished. **Aquinas' Fifth Way** argues that things lacking cognition act for an end, and do so always or nearly always in the same way; such directedness cannot be chance, so they are directed by an intelligent being, as the arrow by the archer. **Paley's** argument, in *Natural Theology* (1802), is instead an **analogy**: finding a watch on a heath, with wheels, cogs, springs and balances all working together to measure time, I cannot attribute it to wind and rain as I could a stone; I must postulate an intelligent maker. Paley adds three riders - the inference survives never having seen a watch made, imperfect working, and parts whose function we cannot discover - and then builds a long **cumulative** case from the eye, the bird's wing, the fish's fin, planetary motion and the seasons.

Hume's critique, in the *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, was published in **1779, twenty-three years before Paley**, who took no apparent account of it. It attacks on five fronts. First, **any** universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation - there could not be birds with wings unable to live in air - so adaptation is a precondition of order, not evidence of design; Hume offers the **Epicurean hypothesis**, that a finite number of particles in random motion will in unlimited time pass through every combination, one of which is a stable order. Second, the **analogy is weak**: the universe resembles a vegetable or a crustacean as much as a machine, and whether those are designed is the very question at issue. Third, **cause must be proportioned to effect**: from a finite world one may infer only a finite cause - his illustration of the scales, where an unseen weight can be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite. Fourth, the evidence equally supports **many** designers, an inferior one, an infant or senile deity, or an abandoned first attempt. Fifth, **evil and disorder** count against a good and powerful designer.

Darwin later supplies a mechanism that removes Paley's biological premise; Hick's ozone example inverts the intuition, since life fitted itself to the filter rather than the filter to life. Modern fine-tuning arguments relocate design to pre-biological constants, answering Hume's first two fronts while remaining fully exposed to the last three, and facing multiverse rivals.

Verdict: Hume does **not** disprove a designer - Philo himself concedes a remote analogy - but he destroys the argument's demonstrative pretension and blocks the passage from an orderer to the one, infinite, perfectly good God of theism. Design survives only as an inference to the best explanation.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: distinguish the two forms -> Paley in full -> Hume's five fronts -> Darwin and fine-tuning -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine**: Way 5's archer-arrow; Paley's watch and three riders.
- **Argument**: the analogy must be displayed as an analogy, with its two relata named.
- **Distinction**: Aquinas ≠ Paley ≠ fine-tuning; and evidential objections (fronts 1-2) versus adequacy objections (fronts 3-5).

- **Technical terms:** Epicurean hypothesis, proportioning cause to effect, means-end adjustment, anthropic selection.
- **Comparison:** Nyāya's *āyojanāt* and the pot-potter model as the Indian analogue.
- **Criticism:** Hume must be given in his own examples, not paraphrased generically.
- **Conclusion:** demonstrative failure plus surviving explanatory force, stated as a graded verdict.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Two forms distinguished - Way 5 vs Paley
 5 min : Paley - the watch, three riders, cumulative evidence
 7 min : Hume's five fronts with his own illustrations; note 1779 vs 1802
 3 min : Darwin (ozone) and fine-tuning; exact scope of each
 2 min : Nyāya's *āyojanāt* as Indian analogue
 2 min : Graded verdict - inference to the best explanation
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Attributing the watch to Aquinas: **factual error, and it wastes the best distinction available.**
- Writing "Hume disproved the design argument": **misstates his conclusion.**
- Giving only two Hume objections in a 20-marker: **thin criticism.**
- Letting Darwin displace Hume: **the question names Hume.**
- Treating fine-tuning as the same argument as Paley's: **category error.**
- Omitting the Indian analogue in Paper II: **loses comparative credit.**

PYQ 12 - 2025, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What proofs do Nyāya philosophers offer for the existence of God? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>What proofs... Discuss</i> - exposition-weighted, with evaluation attached
Core issue	The content and structure of the Nyāya proof-set
Scope boundary	Narrower than 2023's "critically examine": more exposition, less polemic
Ideal thesis	A structured set of mutually reinforcing inferences to an omniscient efficient cause, cumulatively rather than individually persuasive
Non-negotiables	Sanskrit terminology; the efficient-cause thesis; a note that enumerations vary; a short evaluation

Model answer (≈250 words)

Nyāya offers not one proof but an array - the tradition claims as many as ten, though enumerations vary across texts and summaries, so an answer should present the principal ones and say so.

Kāryāt, the causal argument, is central. All composite objects - mountains, seas, sun and moon - are effects, since they are made of parts (*sāvayava*) and possess intermediate magnitude (*avāntara-mahattva*). Space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities; atoms and *manas* as simple infinitesimals. Material causes cannot by themselves attain the order and co-ordination required to produce such effects, so an intelligent maker is needed, possessing direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it. He must be **omniscient**, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms.

Āyojanāt: inert atoms require purposive combination. **Dhṛtyādeḥ**: the world's support, maintenance and destruction imply governance. **Padāt / āptaprāmānya**: the Veda's authority presupposes an omniscient trustworthy author, since no *jīva* can know supramundane realities. **Śruteḥ**: scripture testifies directly. The argument from **adrṣṭa** completes the set: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot itself allot the precise joy and sorrow deserved, nor do selves know or control it; hence God is *karmaphaladātā*, the impartial dispenser.

Throughout, Īśvara is the **efficient, not material, cause**: atoms are eternal, and God orders rather than produces them; He also preserves and destroys, which makes Nyāya theistic rather than deistic.

Discussion: the proofs are mutually reinforcing in Udayana's cumulative manner, but each is contested - Mīmāṃsā by *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva*, Buddhism and Jainism by karmic sufficiency, Cārvāka by restricting *pramāṇas*. They establish a probable cosmic administrator rather than a demonstrated absolute.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** note the plurality of proofs -> present five or six with Sanskrit names -> state the efficient-cause thesis -> short evaluation.
- **Doctrine:** *sāyaya*, *avāntara-mahattva*, the omniscience derivation, *adr̥ṣṭa*, *karmaphaladātā*.
- **Argument:** *kāryāt* must be a reconstruction; the others may be compressed to one or two lines each.
- **Distinction:** efficient versus material cause; theism versus deism.
- **Technical terms:** all six Sanskrit route-names, correctly glossed.
- **Comparison:** one line on the Western parallels (Janet, Lotze, Martineau) and the existence/order divergence.
- **Criticism:** at least three Indian objectors, briefly.
- **Conclusion:** cumulative persuasiveness with a modest terminus.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Plurality of proofs; enumerations vary
 6 min : Karyat in full; ayojanat, dhrtyadeh, padat/sruteh compressed
 3 min : Adrsta argument and karmaphaladata
 2 min : Efficient not material cause; theism not deism
 2 min : Evaluation - Mimamsa, Bauddha/Jaina, Carvaka; cumulative verdict
 Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Answering with the *nature* of Nyāya's God instead of the proofs: **question substitution - a distinct 2021 PYQ**.
- Giving only *kāryāt*: **the question says "proofs", plural**.
- Omitting the omniscience derivation: **loses the argument's most distinctive step**.
- Asserting a fixed canonical list of exactly four or exactly ten: **enumerations genuinely vary; say so**.
- No evaluation at all: **"Discuss" requires some**.

These retained models extend coverage rather than repeat a direct verified PYQ.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 10-marker 1

Question: Distinguish an essentially ordered from an accidentally ordered causal series, and explain why the distinction is indispensable to Aquinas' Second Way. **(10 marks, 150 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Distinguish</i> and <i>explain why</i> - a conceptual distinction put to argumentative work
Core issue	Why Aquinas may exclude one infinite regress without excluding all
Ideal thesis	The distinction shows that "first" means explanatory, not temporal, priority

Model answer (≈155 words)

An **accidentally ordered (per accidens)** series is one in which each cause, having produced its effect, may perish while the effect continues - as a grandfather begets a father who begets a son. Its members possess causal power in their own right, and an infinite backward series of such causes is not obviously incoherent; Aquinas indeed holds that reason alone cannot exclude an eternal world.

An **essentially ordered (per se)** series is one in which the members act simultaneously and the intermediates possess only **derivative** power: the hand moves the stick, which moves the stone. Remove the hand and the whole series stops at once.

The distinction is indispensable because Aquinas' exclusion of infinite regress applies only to the second kind. An unlimited series of borrowers with no owner explains nothing, since no member supplies non-derivative actualising power. Hence "first cause" denotes **explanatory priority here and now**, not the earliest event in time - which is why the Second Way is not an argument for a temporal beginning.

Top-answer checklist

- Both series named in Latin and illustrated.
- Simultaneity and derivative power identified as the marks of the *per se* series.
- The hand-stick-stone example present.
- "First" explicitly glossed as explanatory.
- One line noting that Aquinas permits an eternal world philosophically.

Original 10-marker 2

Question: "Jainism denies God but not godhead." Examine. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - test the accuracy and implications of the formula
Core issue	Two senses of "God": world-maker and perfected being
Ideal thesis	The formula is accurate: Jainism rejects <i>jagat-kartā</i> and affirms attainable divinity

Model answer (≈160 words)

The formula is accurate and philosophically precise. Jainism denies God as **creator**: the world was never made, since all six substances are eternal and reality is characterised by origination, decay and permanence (*utpāda-vyaya-dhrauṇya*); change belongs to modes, not to a divine act. It reinforces this with anti-creator arguments - a perfect being can have no motive to create; creation from compassion is refuted by suffering; creation as sport is childish and cruel; and if God is self-existent, the world may equally be so.

Yet **godhead** is affirmed. Every *jīva* intrinsically possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power, obscured by material karma; complete removal of that obscuration yields *kevala-jñāna*, and the liberated soul is a *siddha* - a god. The Tirthaṅkaras were mortals who reached this by personal effort: "we are all potential Jinas."

Jaina divinity is therefore **plural, achieved, non-creative and exemplary**. It answers the soteriological question, not the cosmological one - which is why the label "atheism" misdescribes it.

Top-answer checklist

- The two senses of "God" separated in the opening line.
- *Utpāda-vyaya-dhrauṇya* cited for the uncreated world.
- At least two anti-creator arguments.
- *Ananta-catuṣṭaya*, *kevala-jñāna*, *siddha* used accurately.
- The closing characterisation: plural, achieved, non-creative, exemplary.

Original 15-marker 1

Question: Does the modal version of the ontological argument escape Kant's objection? Discuss. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss</i> an evaluative question demanding a verdict
Core issue	Whether necessary existence is a modal status immune to the real-predicate objection
Ideal thesis	It escapes the letter of Kant's objection but not its spirit, because the burden migrates to the possibility premise

Model answer (~250 words)

Kant's objection is that existence is not a real or determining predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object, as a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. If so, Anselm's comparative - that existing in reality is *greater* - is illegitimate, and the argument builds its conclusion into its premise.

Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and, most influentially, Plantinga work exclusively with Anselm's second form. Their claim is that the relevant property is not bare existence but **necessary existence**, a modal status. The argument runs: it is possible that a maximally great being exists; a maximally great being exists necessarily and is maximally excellent in every possible world; what is possibly necessary is, in S5, actually necessary; therefore such a being exists.

This does escape Kant's objection **as stated**: modal status is arguably a genuine property of a being, and the inference does not require existence to enhance a concept.

But it does not escape the objection's **spirit**. The entire weight now falls on the **possibility premise**. A symmetrical premise - that it is possible that no maximally great being exists - yields, in the same modal system, the contradictory conclusion. The premises are thus evidentially on a par, and the argument establishes nothing until it is independently shown that maximal greatness is **coherent**. That is precisely the question Kant's objection was raising in another form: whether the concept of God can be so specified that its analysis yields existence.

Verdict: the modal version converts an objection about the logic of existence into a dispute about the coherence of maximal greatness. This is philosophical progress, not vindication.

Top-answer checklist

- Kant's objection stated with the thaler illustration.
- The modal argument given as numbered steps, with S5 named.
- The escape acknowledged honestly before the counter is made.
- The symmetry of the possibility premise displayed.
- A graded verdict - progress, not vindication.

Original 15-marker 2

Question: Examine the Mīmāṃsā case that the authority of the Veda and the operation of karma together render a creator God redundant. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - reconstruct the case and test it
Core issue	Whether normativity and desert can be secured without a divine guarantor
Ideal thesis	The case is coherent and internally powerful, but purchases economy at the cost of explaining normativity's ultimate ground

Model answer (~250 words)

Mīmāṃsā's case has two limbs, each aimed at a distinct Nyāya proof.

The first concerns **authority**. The Veda is **apauruṣeya** - eternal, authorless and self-valid. Authorlessness is not a deficiency but a protection: a personal author may deceive or may lack complete knowledge, and if the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on first proving that author's competence and sincerity. Mīmāṃsā presses the point directly against Nyāya: the theistic route requires proving that God exists, then that God is omniscient, then that God intends truth, each stage needing independent support. Combined with **svataḥ-prāmāṇya**, the intrinsic validity of cognition, authorlessness blocks scepticism at the outset without theological machinery.

The second concerns **desert**. **Apūrva** is the unseen potency generated by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit. Prābhākara adds **niyoga**: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one acts because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards. Together these dissolve Nyāya's *adṛṣṭa* argument, whose whole force lay in the claim that an unconscious principle cannot allot determinate fruit.

Two criticisms remain. First, an eternal, authorless language that nevertheless carries determinate normative content is itself philosophically striking, and Nyāya charges that unexplained normativity is not the same as economical explanation. Second, Chatterjee and Datta observe that Mīmāṃsā's deities are not treated as objects of worship and are said to exist nowhere except in the *mantras* describing them, so God is left in an "ambiguous position" - economy achieved partly by evacuation.

Verdict: the case succeeds in showing that a rigorous account of duty and desert is possible without a creator; it does not show that such an account is explanatorily superior.

Top-answer checklist

- The two limbs separated and matched to the two Nyāya proofs they attack.
- *Apauruṣeya*, *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*, *apūrva* and *niyoga* all used correctly.
- The "cumbersome three-stage dependence" objection to Nyāya reproduced.
- At least one criticism from the Nyāya side and one from the textbook tradition.
- A graded verdict distinguishing possibility from superiority.

Original 20-marker 1

Question: "Hume did not disprove design; he dismantled the inference." Critically examine with reference to the Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion. **(20 marks, 340 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> a precise interpretive thesis
Core issue	The logical status of Hume's conclusions
Ideal thesis	The thesis is correct: Hume's attacks are undercutting and adequacy-directed, not disproofs

Model answer (≈350 words)

The thesis is correct, and defending it requires separating two waves of Hume's attack.

The design argument, in Paley's form, is an **analogy**: a watch on a heath, with wheels, cogs and springs adjusted to a purpose, obliges us to postulate a maker; organisms exhibit comparable means-end adjustment; therefore they too imply a designer. Paley's three riders pre-empt the obvious replies - the inference survives never having seen a watch made, imperfect working, and parts of unknown function - and he builds a long cumulative case from the eye, the wing, the fin, planetary motion and the seasons.

Hume's **first wave is undercutting**. He argues that any universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation, so adaptation is a precondition of order rather than evidence of design; the **Epicurean hypothesis** - a finite number of particles in random motion passing, in unlimited time, through every combination, one of which is stable - supplies a naturalistic model of order. He then attacks the analogy itself: the universe is as like a vegetable or a crustacean as a machine, and whether *those* are designed is the point at issue.

His **second wave is adequacy-directed**. Cause must be proportioned to effect, so from a finite world one may infer only a finite cause - the illustration of the scales, where an unseen weight may be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite. The evidence equally supports many designers, an inferior deity, an infant or senile one, or a bungled first attempt; and the world's evil and disorder tell against a good and powerful designer.

Neither wave is a **disproof**. Undercutting objections show the evidence does not support the conclusion; they do not show the conclusion false. Adequacy objections *grant* an inference and deny only its reach. Hume's own Philo concedes a remote, undefined analogy between the cause of order in the universe and human intelligence. Darwin later supplies the mechanism Hume lacked, removing Paley's biological premise - Hick's ozone example inverts the intuition - but that too is an explanation, not a refutation. Modern fine-tuning arguments answer Hume's first wave by relocating the evidence to pre-biological constants, while remaining fully exposed to the second and facing multiverse rivals.

Verdict: the thesis stands. Hume destroyed the argument's demonstrative pretension and blocked the passage from an orderer to the one, infinite, perfectly good God of theism. What survives is design as an **inference to the best explanation** - contested, cumulative, and never compelling.

Top-answer checklist

- The two waves explicitly distinguished and labelled by tier.
- Paley's three riders present.
- At least four Hume fronts with his own illustrations.
- Philo's concession cited as the decisive textual evidence for the thesis.
- Darwin and fine-tuning placed with their exact scope.
- A verdict naming what survives, not merely what fails.

Original 20-marker 2

Question: "Every Indian argument against a creator God is either an economy move, a coherence move or an epistemic move." Critically examine this classification with reference to Jaina, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka positions. (20 marks, 340 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> a proposed taxonomy - test its fit and its limits
Core issue	Whether four distinct schools share a common argumentative structure
Ideal thesis	The classification fits well and is analytically useful, but some arguments straddle categories and one school resists placement

Model answer (≈350 words)

The classification is largely accurate and analytically valuable, though it requires two qualifications.

Economy moves claim that the explanandum is already explained. Buddhism's **pratītyasamutpāda** accounts for the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator superfluous; the critique is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus rather than bare denial. Jainism holds that the world was never created - substances are eternal and change through modes - and that material karma, adhering to each jīva, accounts for the distribution of fortune. Mīmāṃsā's **apūrva** matures into its own fruit, displacing the need for a dispenser. Cārvāka holds that the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements.

Coherence moves claim that the divine attributes are inconsistent with the act of creating. Buddhism argues that an eternal, immutable cause cannot produce **successive** effects, and that creation from desire implies lack. Jainism asks what God created from, why a perfect being would create at all, and why a compassionate creator's world contains suffering. Chatterjee and Datta record Max Müller's related point that a creator would be liable to charges of cruelty and partiality.

Epistemic moves deny that the required *pramāṇa* is available. Cārvāka restricts valid cognition to perception, which undercuts every inferential proof at the outset. Mīmāṃsā's **svataḥ-prāmāṇya** and **apauruṣeya** make Vedic authority intrinsic, so no divine certifier is needed; Nyāya's route, requiring one to prove God, then omniscience, then truthfulness, is dismissed as cumbersome.

Two qualifications. First, several arguments straddle categories: the Jaina "if God is self-existent, so may the world be" is simultaneously a parity argument and an economy argument, and Buddhism's *avyākṛta* silence is methodological rather than any of the three. Second, Jainism does not fit a purely negative taxonomy, since it also **affirms** godhood - every liberated soul is a god - so its position is not exhausted by objections to a creator.

Nyāya's replies fall into matching families: against economy, that an unconscious principle cannot allot determinate desert; against coherence, that divine agency need not be modelled on finite volition; against epistemic restriction, that inference is an independent *pramāṇa* which the Cārvāka's own general denial presupposes.

Verdict: the taxonomy is a genuine advance over school-by-school listing, because it exposes that Indian and Western critiques share the same three structures - Hume's Epicurean hypothesis is an economy move, his proportioning principle a coherence-adjacent adequacy move, and logical positivist verificationism an epistemic move. It should be used as a framework, not as a straitjacket.

Top-answer checklist

- All four schools placed, with at least one school appearing in two categories.
- Sanskrit terms deployed as analytical instruments.
- The Nyāya replies mapped onto the same three families.
- At least two honest limits to the classification.
- A Western cross-mapping in the verdict.

High-score proof-answer protocol

1. Define with discrimination, not description

Open with a definition that already separates the doctrine from its nearest rival.

Weak : God is the cause of the world.

Strong: In Nyaya, Isvara is the intelligent EFFICIENT cause who orders eternal atoms; atoms remain the MATERIAL cause, and God also preserves and destroys - which distinguishes Nyaya theism from deism.

Term	The definition must distinguish it from
Ontological argument	Cosmological reasoning and Descartes' <i>Meditations</i> III causal proof
Necessary being	Whatever merely happens to be everlasting
<i>Per se</i> series	<i>Per accidens</i> series
Design (Way 5)	Paley's analogy and modern fine-tuning
Postulate	Demonstration and empirical hypothesis
<i>Adṛṣṭa</i>	Jaina material karma and Mīmāṃsā <i>apūrva</i>
<i>Apauruṣeya</i>	Divine revelation

2. Reconstruct arguments as premises

1. Composite objects are effects (savayava + avantara-mahattva).
2. Material causes alone cannot achieve the required order.
3. An intelligent cause must know the atoms, desire an end and will it.
4. Only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.
5. The cause is an omniscient God.

Then expose the **presupposition** - here, that world-wholes are relevantly like artefacts. Marks come from showing *why* the conclusion follows and *where* it can be resisted.

3. Sort every objection by tier

VALIDITY : does the conclusion follow? (quantifier shift in Way 3)
 SOUNDNESS : are the premises true? (Hume fronts 1-2; Darwin)
 ADEQUACY : is the being reached GOD? (Hume front 3; Kant on cosmological)

Announcing the tier in a single clause - "this is an objection to adequacy, not to validity" - signals control and saves words.

4. Use Sanskrit and Latin as instruments, not decoration

- Gloss on first use: *kāryāt* (from the effect), *per se* (essentially ordered).
- Preserve causal distinctions: *nimitta-kāraṇa* versus *upādāna-kāraṇa*.
- Preserve epistemic distinctions: *pratyakṣa*, *anumāna*, *śabda*, *vyāpti*.
- Preserve the three Kantian statuses: knowledge, postulate, idea of reason.

5. Never conflate these five relations

CONCEPTUAL ENTAILMENT : Anselm - the concept contains necessary existence
EXPLANATORY PRIORITY : Aquinas - the first cause acts here and now
ANALOGICAL INFERENCE : Paley, Nyaya - artefact to world
PRACTICAL POSTULATION : Kant - required for the highest good's possibility
SCRIPTURAL TESTIMONY : Nyaya sruteh - and its Mimamsa denial

6. Present objection and reply dialectically

OBJECTION -> BEST AVAILABLE REPLY -> RESIDUAL PRESSURE

Objection : An infinite regress of causes needs no first member.

Reply : The series is essentially ordered; derivative causes supply no actualising power however many they are.

Residual : It must still be shown that the actual causal order is per se rather than per accidens.

Steelman the critic before evaluating. Never introduce a weak objection merely to dismiss it.

7. Grade the verdict and name the criterion

Avoid "completely proved", "totally refuted", "both are equally valid". Prefer:

- "valid in form but question-begging in premise",
- "evidentially undercut, though not disproved",
- "explanatorily economical but normatively unexplained",
- "epistemically bolder and correspondingly more exposed",
- "adequate to a cosmic administrator, not to an absolute".

Name the criterion: coherence, evidential contact, modal strength, explanatory economy, religious adequacy, or compatibility with moral agency.

8. Marks-wise architecture

Marks	Working time	Architecture
10	7-8 min	Classify -> premises -> one presupposition -> canonical objection -> one-line verdict
15	12-13 min	Frame -> reconstruct -> canonical example -> strongest objection -> best reply -> assess validity and adequacy separately
20	17-18 min	Classify family -> full steps -> Indian/Western contrast -> two objections with replies -> underdetermination of attributes -> criterion-named verdict

- **10 marks ≈ 150 words.** One controlled comparison is enough; do not spend half the answer on background.
- **15 marks ≈ 220-260 words.** At least one technical distinction and one serious criticism.
- **20 marks ≈ 320-360 words.** A comparative matrix or compact diagram may precede the prose; two objections, or one developed through reply and residual pressure.

9. Avoid generic prose

Do not write:

"Belief in God gives peace and moral values to society."

Write:

"A moral governor can ground desert-appropriate allocation, but Mīmāṃsā's *apūrva* shows that an unconscious potency may be intrinsically fruit-directed - so the Nyāya inference must defend its premise that unconsciousness entails indeterminacy of outcome."

10. Final twenty-second audit

- Did I answer the **directive** - examine, compare, critically evaluate, discuss?
- Did I define the controlling term so as to exclude its nearest rival?
- Did I reconstruct at least one argument as numbered premises?

- Did I name the **tier** of each objection?
- Did I include Indian material in a Paper II answer?
- Did I state a **graded verdict with a named criterion**?

Final rapid revision matrix

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
Ontological, first form	Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> 2	Concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived	Existence in reality	Gaunilo's island; Kant's real predicate	Is the ontological proof logical?
Ontological, second form	Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> 3	The same concept plus inconceivability of non-existence	Necessary existence, aseity	Coherence of maximal greatness	Does the concept entail existence?
Essence-containment	Descartes, <i>Meditations</i> V	Essence of a supremely perfect being	Existence as a perfection	Kant; second-order analysis of existence	Exposition with criticism
Island parody	Gaunilo	Any maximally perfect object	Absurd conclusions	Answered by necessary existence	Criticism of Anselm
Real-predicate objection	Kant, <i>CPR</i>	Logic of "exists"	Existence posits, does not enrich	Modal repair attempts	Criticism of the ontological proof
Modal ontological	Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga	Possibility of maximal greatness	Necessary existence in S5	Possibility premise is symmetric	Advanced note only
Way 1	Aquinas	Motion / change	Unmoved mover	Regress exclusion	Five Ways exposition
Way 2	Aquinas	Order of efficient causes	First efficient cause	Hume on regress; Kant on identification	Five Ways; comparison with Nyāya
Way 3	Aquinas	Contingency	Necessary being, ultimately a se	Quantifier shift	Most interesting Way
Way 4	Aquinas	Degrees of perfection	Maximum, cause of all perfection	Degrees need no maximum	Five Ways completeness
Way 5	Aquinas	Regular directedness of non-cognitive nature	Directing intelligence (archer-arrow)	Hume's analogy; less exposed to Darwin	Design argument
Kalām	Islamic tradition; modern revival	Universe began to exist	Personal, timeless, powerful cause	Actual-infinite and cosmology disputes	Contrast with Aquinas
PSR version	Leibniz	Why anything rather than nothing	Necessary being	Brute-fact reply	Cosmological evaluation
Watch analogy	Paley, <i>Natural Theology</i> 1802	Means-end adjustment in organisms	Intelligent maker	Darwin; Hume's five fronts	Design with Hume's criticism
Five-front critique	Hume, <i>Dialogues</i> 1779	Analogy, adaptation, proportion, plurality, evil	Design inference dismantled	Does not disprove a designer	2025-type question
Natural selection	Darwin	Variation and differential survival	Adaptation without design	Does not touch fine-tuning or law	Extension of the design debate
Fine-tuning	Modern probabilistic theism	Life-permitting constants	Design as best explanation	Multiverse; observation selection	Contemporary note only
Moral, first form	Newman	Conscience and objective values	Divine Law Giver	Begs the question against naturalism	Critical account of the moral argument

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
Moral, second form	Kant, <i>CPR</i>	Moral law and the highest good	God, immortality, freedom as postulates	Projection; autonomy; adequacy	Critical account; comparison with Nyāya
<i>Kāryāt</i>	Nyāya / Udayana	Composite world as effect (<i>sāvayava</i> , <i>avāntara-mahattva</i>)	Omniscient intelligent maker	World unlike an artefact	Nyāya proofs
<i>Āyojanāt</i>	Nyāya	Purposive combination of inert atoms	Conscious arranger	Order may emerge unintentionally	Nyāya proofs
<i>Dhṛtyādeḥ</i>	Nyāya	Support, maintenance, destruction	Cosmic governor	Governance may be law-like	Nyāya proofs
<i>Padāt / āptaprāmānya</i>	Nyāya	Authority of the Veda	Omniscient trustworthy author	Mīmāṃsā <i>apauruṣeya</i>	Nyāya proofs; circularity
<i>Śruteḥ</i>	Nyāya	Scriptural testimony	God as attested	Circularity charge; philosophical weight of testimony	Nyāya proofs
<i>Adṛṣṭa</i> argument	Nyāya	Unequal fortunes; time-gap of desert	God as <i>karmaphaladātā</i>	Mīmāṃsā <i>apūrva</i> ; redundancy	Nyāya; comparison with Kant
Nyāya causation	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Eternal atoms and souls	God as efficient, not material, cause	Sharma: "reduced to a supervisor"	Nature versus proofs - keep distinct
Jaina godhead	Jainism	<i>Ananta-catuṣṭaya</i> obscured by material karma	<i>Kevala-jñāna</i> ; the <i>siddha</i> as god	Bondage/liberation dilemma	Jaina proofs (2019)
Jaina anti-creator	Jainism	Uncreated world; modes	No creator needed	Presupposes Jaina metaphysics	Jaina proofs
Buddhist anti-creator	Buddhism	Dependent origination; immutability	Creator redundant and incoherent	Nyāya on determinate allocation	2018 Q8(b)
Mīmāṃsā	Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā	<i>Apauruṣeya</i> Veda; <i>apūrva</i>	Authority and desert without God	Normativity left unexplained	Critique of Nyāya proofs
Cārvāka	Cārvāka	Perception as sole <i>pramāṇa</i>	God unproven and unnecessary	Denial itself uses inference	Anti-theistic arguments
Advaita levelling	Śāṅkara	Levels of reality	Nyāya's God is only <i>saguṇa</i>	Level-distinction dispute	Comparative synthesis
Cumulative case	Udayana; modern theists	Multiple independent routes	Higher overall probability	Independence and logical type	20-mark evaluation

Last-minute memory spine

TIERS : validity -> soundness -> adequacy of the God established
 A PRIORI : ontological only | A POSTERIORI : cosmo · teleo · moral · Nyaya
 ANSELM : P2 existence · P3 NECESSARY existence · Gaunilo · Kant · modal burden
 AQUINAS : motion · causation · contingency · degrees · purpose
 per se (hand-stick-stone) · "first" = explanatory · eternity permitted
 DESIGN : Way 5 archer ≠ Paley watch ≠ fine-tuning constants
 HUME : A-A-P-P-E - adapted · analogy · proportion · plurality · evil
 (1779, BEFORE Paley 1802; Philo concedes a remote analogy)
 KANT : CPR destroys · CPR postulates · F-I-G · summum bonum · ought-implies-can
 NYAYA : K-A-D-P-S + adrsta · EFFICIENT cause only · karmaphaladata ·
 order-of-existence vs order-of-knowledge
 INDIA : Jaina godhead · Buddha conditions · Mimamsa apauruseya + apurva ·
 Carvaka perception · Advaita saguna · Sharma redundancy
 CLASSIFY : every Indian objection = Economy · Coherence · Epistemic
 VERDICT : classify -> reconstruct -> presuppose -> object -> reply -> GRADE

End of the premium solved-PYQ and practice workbook.

Timed-paper compression plan

ANALYSIS: Use this only after the full models above. It converts each solved answer into an examination-length script without discarding the elements that earn marks.

Demand type in this clause	Keep at every length	Cut first, in this order
Single-proof exposition (2020 Anselm; 2024 ontological; 2025 design)	the numbered premise chain; the canonical example; the named critic's objection; the graded verdict	the argument's later reception history, then the biography of the proponent, then the second illustration
Two-part directive (2025 Q6(a); 2024 Q7(c))	the visible split between exposition and critique; the printed mark-weighting	the introduction's scene-setting; any objection beyond the two strongest
Comparison (2018 Aquinas and Nyāya)	the announced axis; both sides on each axis; the being/order divergence	the third and fourth axes; the Sanskrit terms whose content you cannot state in a clause
Enumeration with premises (2023 and 2025 Nyāya)	one clause of content per named ground; the unseen-potency argument; one critic per ground	the eighth ground (<i>saṃkhyāviśeṣāt</i>) unless you can state it correctly; the internal circularity reply
Trap-shaped stem (2019 Jainism)	the first-line correction; three anti-creator arguments; the ford-maker/liberated-soul distinction	the remaining three anti-creator arguments; the five-fold salutation detail
Anti-creator evaluation (2018 Buddhism)	the successive-or-simultaneous dilemma; the redundancy point; the Nyāya reply and the rejoinder	the canonical-genetic stratum, compressed to one sentence; the sutta references
Conceptual distinction (2022 a priori and a posteriori)	the source-of-premises rule; one example each side; the criterion-named preference	the historical illustration; the modal-logic detail
Evaluative choice (2022 Five Ways)	the criterion, stated before the choice; the chosen Way's premises; the cost of the choice	the four Ways not chosen, reduced to one line each

ANALYSIS: **Band budgets for this topic.** 10 marks ≈ 150 words: classification, premises, one presupposition, one objection, one-line verdict. 15 marks ≈ 220-260 words: add the canonical example, the proponent's reply, and separated verdicts on validity and adequacy. 20 marks ≈ 320-360 words: add the Indian or Western analogue, a second objection with its reply, and the underdetermination point before a criterion-named conclusion.

ANALYSIS: **What never gets cut:** the distinction between validity, soundness and adequacy; the attribution of the watch to Paley; the efficient-not-material role of the Nyāya Lord; and the closing statement of what the argument actually establishes.